



CITY: Pg 3

Heat creeps back, but rain awaits city



WORLD: Pg 6

'Ceasefire' holds as US awaits Iran response, Bahrain detains dozens



FILM: Pg 12

'Almost gave up, but it kept coming back'

MLAs OF THE RULING BJP AND OPPOSITION PARTIES MAY TAKE OATH ON MAY 13 AND 14

Bengal's 9th, BJP's 1st CM: Suvendu takes oath

PRADIP CHATTERJEE

KOLKATA: In a historical moment drenched with political symbolism and intense emotion, Suvendu Adhikari was sworn in as the 9th Chief Minister of West Bengal and the BJP's first-ever CM in the state at the iconic Brigade Parade Ground on Saturday.

The ceremony marked a watershed in Bengal's political history, formally ushering in the saffron party's maiden government in the state since Independence, following its emphatic victory in the 2026 Assembly elections.

The high-voltage event was attended by PM Modi, Home minister Amit Shah, Defence minister Rajnath Singh, alongside senior BJP leaders, top dignitaries and the CM's of NDA-ruled states, turning Brigade into the focal point of a major political transformation in the state.

This ended the Trinamool Congress's 15-year rule in the state.

Along with Adhikari, five other winning candidates of BJP took oath as the council of ministers.

The Bengal Cabinet will be expanded later. With a limit of 44 ministers, 39 more MLAs can join the Bengal government under CM Suvendu Adhikari.

Five ministers – Dilip Ghosh, Agnimitra Paul, Nisith Pramanik, Ashok Kirtania, and Kshudiram Tudu – also took oath. Governor RN Ravi administered the oath of office and secrecy.

Sources said that the Cabinet ministers may take oaths between Monday and Friday next week. The first Cabinet meeting of the newly formed government is likely to take place next Friday.

Tapas Roy, who won from Maniktala, is likely to take oath as the pro-tem Speaker of the West Bengal Legislative Assembly on Tuesday. Sources said that Adhikari will accompany Roy to Lok Bhawan, where Governor RN Ravi will administer the oath.

The MLAs of the ruling BJP and Opposition parties may take oath on May 13 and 14. Once the MLAs are sworn in, the process of electing the Speaker will begin. It was learnt that the chair used by the former Chief Minister, Mamata Banerjee, was sent to the room where the Opposition MLAs sit.

Adhikari took the oath at around 11.30 am. Union ministers Rajnath Singh, Shivraj Singh Chouhan were also present. All BJP chief ministers, including Devendra Fadnavis, Himanta Biswa Sarma and Yogi Adityanath, were present at the swearing-in ceremony.

PM Modi entered the swearing-in ceremony venue in an open car flanked by Suvendu Adhikari and BJP state president Samik Bhattacharya. Notably, Suvendu Adhikari sported a saffron shirt.

About 100 metres from the stage, Modi got out of the car and walked towards the dais. Once on the stage, he bowed down to thank the people of Bengal.

Continued on P4



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets a gathering upon his arrival for the swearing-in ceremony of party leader Suvendu Adhikari, at Brigade Parade Ground, in Kolkata, on Saturday



Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulates newly-sworn West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari after taking oath during a ceremony, in Kolkata, on Saturday

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“THE SACRIFICES OF BJP WORKERS WOULD REMAIN A SOURCE OF STRENGTH FOR THE PARTY”

— PM MODI

“WE NEED TO BRING BACK THE LOST GLORY OF BENGAL, WHICH HIT ROCK BOTTOM UNDER THE TMC GOVERNMENT”

— SUVENDU ADHIKARI

HISTORIC MOMENT

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I am CM now, and I belong to everybody, says Suvendu

STRIKING A BALANCE

Suvendu leads new Cabinet with five ministers, portfolios expected next week

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Besides the swearing-in of the first BJP Chief Minister of Bengal, Suvendu Adhikari, five council of ministers have also taken oath in the presence of PM Modi and Union Home minister Amit Shah, among other top dignitaries at Brigade Parade Ground on Saturday.

The choice of ministers indicated the BJP's attempt to balance caste equations. These legislators who will serve in Adhikari's Cabinet include Dilip Ghosh, Agnimitra Paul, Nisith Pramanik, Kshudiram Tudu, and Ashok Kirtania. The Bengal Cabinet will be expanded later. Sources said the portfolios of the new cabinets may be distributed next week.

Dilip Ghosh, a veteran BJP leader and former state party president, will play a crucial role in the new Cabinet. Originally



BJP ministers Agnimitra Paul, Kshudiram Tudu, Dilip Ghosh, Nisith Pramanik and Ashok Kirtania, take oath of office, in Kolkata, on Saturday

PICS/GAUTAM BOSE

CLOSER LOOK

» The choice of ministers indicated the BJP's attempt to balance caste equations

» Originally associated with the RSS as a full-time campaigner, Dilip Ghosh played a significant role in expanding the BJP's grassroots network in Bengal after 2014

» Another key player in Adhikari's Cabinet is Agnimitra Paul
» Nisith Pramanik, belonging to the Rajbongshi community, is one of the BJP's prominent leaders from North Bengal

associated with the RSS as a full-time campaigner, Ghosh played a significant role in expanding the BJP's grassroots network in Bengal after 2014. He belongs to the Other Backwards Classes

(OBC) community. Ghosh was the Member of Parliament representing the Medinipur constituency in the Lok Sabha.

Another key player in Adhikari's Cabinet is Agnim-

itra Paul, who is going to be a woman minister in the BJP's Bengal Cabinet. Paul, who was a fashion designer-turned-politician, joined the BJP in 2019.

Continued on P4

Modi bows to Bengal's 'jana shakti', wishes Suvendu 'fruitful tenure'



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets a gathering upon his arrival for the swearing-in ceremony

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SOUMITRA NANDI

TAKE A BOW

KOLKATA: At a historic moment during the swearing-in of Suvendu Adhikari as Bengal's 9th and BJP's first Chief Minister, Prime Minister Narendra Modi bowed with folded hands before the people, thanking them for delivering a sweeping mandate to the BJP—marking a dramatic political shift that brought the party from the margins of the state's long-dominant ideological landscape to the centre of power after decades of waiting.

The PM's gesture at the iconic Brigade Parade Ground on Saturday added an emotional intensity to a ceremony already seen as a watershed moment in Bengal's political history. The Prime Minister first waved to the crowd and then slowly bent down as a mark of respect towards what he called the “jana shakti” or people's power of Bengal.

Continued on P4

» PM Modi calls the victory a historic transformation, bringing BJP from the margins to the centre of power in West Bengal

» PM congratulates Suvendu Adhikari, praises his connect with people, and wishes him a “fruitful tenure” on X

» Senior BJP leaders, including Amit Shah and NDA chief ministers attend the high-profile swearing-in ceremony

ED arrests Punjab Min Sanjeev Arora

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/CHAN-DIGARH: The Enforcement Directorate on Saturday arrested Punjab industries minister Sanjeev Arora in connection with a new money laundering case involving him and several entities allegedly linked to him, officials said. According to officials, Arora (62) was taken into custody under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) following early morning raids at his official residence in Chandigarh. They noted that he was “non-cooperative” during the investigation and will be brought to Delhi.

See P5

TRIBUTE



Prime Minister Narendra Modi pays tributes to Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore upon his arrival for the swearing-in ceremony of party leader Suvendu Adhikari, unseen, as he becomes West Bengal's first BJP Chief Minister, at Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata

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New CDS, Navy Chief appointed

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Lt Gen NS Raja Subramani (ret'd) has been named India's next Chief of Defence Staff and his primary mandate will be to implement the ambitious military theatreisation plan and bolster tri-services synergy. The government has also appointed Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan as the next Chief of the Naval Staff. While Lt Gen Subramani will replace incumbent Gen Anil Chauhan as the country's senior-most military commander, Vice Admiral Swaminathan will succeed Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi as the Navy Chief, according to an official statement.

See P4

TN: 120 reasons for Vijay to smile

Vijay to take oath at 10 am today

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: The suspense and uncertainty over government formation in Tamil Nadu came to an end on Saturday with superstar Vijay's TVK clinching key support to cross the magic 118 majority mark in the Tamil Nadu Assembly.

Finally, TVK chief Chandrasekar Joseph Vijay will be sworn in as the Chief Minister of the state on Sunday.

A top-rated actor-politician, the 51-year-old Vijay will be sworn in as the CM at the sprawling Jawaharlal Nehru Indoor Stadium here at 10 AM on Sunday, the Lok Bhavan said.

Capping days of hectic parleying to shore up num-



Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar hands over the letter of appointment to TVK chief C Joseph Vijay as the new state Chief Minister, at the Lok Bhavan, in Chennai, on Saturday

PTI

bers to usher in the first non-DMK, non-AIADMK government in nearly 70 years, Vijay finally managed to secure the support of four MLAs of Viduthala Chiruthaigal

Continued on P4

PMJJBY, PMSBY settle claims worth ₹25,160 crore since launch in 2015

PMJJBY, PMSBY & APY envisioned to extend financial protection to all, particularly under-served and vulnerable sections of society

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Jansuraksha schemes like Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana have settled claims of about Rs 25,160 crore since their launch in 2015, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Saturday.

Jan Suraksha schemes Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY), Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY), and Atal Pension Yojana (APY) envisioned to extend affordable financial protection to all, particularly the under-served and vulnerable sections of society, were launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on May 9, 2015.

These flagship schemes, which completed 11 years, aim to broaden the insurance and pension landscape by shielding citizens against life's uncertainties and fostering long-term financial resilience.

Citing data on the 11th anniversaries of the Jan Suraksha Schemes, Sitharaman said that over 27 crore, 58 crore and 9 crore enrolments have been done under PMJJBY, PMSBY and APY, respectively.

On PMJJBY, she said the



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

Sitharaman said that over 27 crore, 58 crore and 9 crore enrolments have been done under PMJJBY, PMSBY and APY, respectively

scheme has settled claims worth more than Rs 21,500 crore for over 10.7 lakh families.

Under PMSBY scheme, Sitharaman said it has settled claims worth nearly Rs 3,660 crore for over 1.84 lakh families.

"As we mark the 11th anniversary of the Jan Suraksha schemes, heartfelt appreciation for all the stakeholders,

Highlights

» On PMJJBY, Sitharaman said the scheme has settled claims worth more than Rs 21,500 crore for over 10.7 lakh families

» Under PMSBY scheme, Sitharaman said it has settled claims worth nearly Rs 3,660 crore for over 1.84 lakh families

» Launched in 2015, PMJJBY offers life insurance cover for death due to any cause at an annual premium of Rs 436. It provides Rs 2 lakh to nominee in event of the subscriber's death

branches or post offices, and the digitising the claims process, has ensured faster settlements, enabling timely support to bereaved families when they need it the most.

"As we celebrate the 11th anniversaries of the three-social security (Jan Suraksha) schemes -- PMJJBY, PMSBY and APY, let us recount how these schemes have enabled affordable insurance and security to people (Jan Suraksha), their achievements and salient features," he said.

Launched in 2015, PMJJBY offers life insurance cover for death due to any cause at an annual premium of Rs 436. Eligible individuals between 18 and 50 years can enrol through participating banks or post offices. It provides Rs 2 lakh to the nominee in the event of the subscriber's death.

As of April 29, the scheme has recorded 12.72 crore female enrolments and 8.09 crore enrolments from PMJDY account holders, the finance ministry said in a statement.

The PMSBY scheme offers accidental death and disability insurance to individuals aged 18 to 70 years at a nominal premium of Rs 20 per annum.

The scheme pays Rs 2 lakh for accidental death or total

disability and Rs 1 lakh for partial disability.

As on April 29, 2026, the scheme has recorded 27.45 crore female enrolments and 19.30 crore enrolments from PMJDY account holders, it said.

Atal Pension Yojana aims to provide old-age income security to unorganised sector workers. It guarantees a monthly pension of Rs 1,000 to Rs 5,000 after the age of 60, depending on the contribution. The scheme is administered by the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) under the National Pension System (NPS) framework.

Open to bank account holders aged 18 to 40 years who are not income tax payers, the scheme has seen over 7.66 crore enrolments till April 2025.

Subscribers can choose monthly, quarterly, or half-yearly contribution modes.

In case of a subscriber's death before the age of 60, the spouse may continue contributing until the original retirement age or withdraw the accumulated corpus.

As on April 30, 2026, more than 9.04 crore individuals have enrolled in the scheme, it added.

Reserve Bank officers seek gov's intervention on promotion policy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: RBI officers' union has written a letter to RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, seeking his intervention to correct the promotion policy and restore a time-bound system.

RBI officers across various regional offices and the central bank's headquarters in Mumbai staged protests on Friday against recent policy changes that link promotions to vacancy availability, replacing the earlier time-bound promotion system.

Reserve Bank of India Officers' Association (RBIOA), in a letter dated May 8, expressed disappointment and anguish over the decision of the central bank to proceed with the revised promotion policy without adequately considering the serious concerns, objections, and constructive suggestions repeatedly placed by the association on behalf of the officer community.

The revised policy, in its present form, has caused widespread dissatisfaction, frustration and demoralisation among officers across cadres and grades, it added.

Citing past interactions with officers at various regional offices, it said that you (Governor) had indicated the possibility of a few time-bound promotions.

However, the final policy has not only failed to address the structural stagnation prevailing across grades but has also disregarded the core concerns repeatedly highlighted by the association, it pointed out.



RBI officers across various regional offices and the central bank's headquarters in Mumbai staged protests on Friday against recent policy changes that link promotions to vacancy availability

According to an estimate, about 8,000 officers working at the RBI are going to be impacted by the change in the promotion policy.

Stagnation is rising across the various levels, leading to frustration, particularly among younger officers, who are now confronted with the prospect of remaining in the same grade for prolonged periods without meaningful progression, it said.

"We earnestly request the top management to reconsider the matter urgently and initiate a comprehensive review of the revised promotion policy in consultation with RBIOA so as to arrive at a fair, balanced

and sustainable framework for career progression of officers," it noted.

The association demanded that the newly issued promotion policy be immediately kept in abeyance and reviewed comprehensively in consultation with RBIOA through a structured and meaningful consultation mechanism.

It also demanded that the assured, time-bound promotions may be introduced across all cadres from Grade A to Grade E, ensuring fair and predictable career progression for officers.

The principle of 'One Grade, One Allowance' may be introduced across grades by removing the existing condition of a minimum of five years' service in a grade for eligibility to facilities, allowances and entitlements attached to that grade, it said.

The letter further said that the association submits that the above measures are not merely matters of financial benefit but are essential for restoring morale, institutional trust and long-term organisational commitment among officers.

A motivated and professionally secure officer community remains indispensable to preserving the excellence, independence and effectiveness of the Reserve Bank of India, it added.

It is to be noted that the officers of another financial sector regulator, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), had also staged a protest in 2024 to press for wage-related issues.

Adani Agri Fresh Ltd to soon procure cherries from Himachal

SHIMLA: Adani Agri Fresh Ltd (AAFL), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Adani Enterprises Limited, on Saturday announced that it will soon begin procuring stone fruits, especially cherries, from Himachal Pradesh.

"We will begin cherry procurement from the upcoming season and gradually expand into other stone fruits such as peaches and plums. This is part of our continued effort to build on our apple procurement experience and provide better market access to farmers," a company spokesperson said.

He said that this initiative is expected to improve fruit storage life, provide farmers access to larger markets, and ensure better prices for their produce.

"AAFL has been among the first organised companies involved in apple procurement, storage, and marketing in Himachal Pradesh. The company started operations in 2006 under the Farm-Pik brand. Since then, it has procured over 300,000 metric tonnes of apples from over 17,000 farmers and has directly paid nearly Rs 1,500 crore to farmers," the official said.

The company has developed a total storage capacity of 25,000 metric tonnes in Himachal Pradesh, helping preserve fruits for longer durations and enabling farmers to access larger markets, he said.

CBI searches 17 Mumbai locations in 3 cases against Reliance ADA cos

NEW DELHI: The CBI on Saturday conducted searches at 17 premises in Mumbai in connection with three cases registered against Reliance ADA Group companies Reliance Telecom Limited, Reliance Commercial Finance Limited and Reliance Home Finance Limited and their directors, officials said.

"These searches are being conducted at the residential premises of directors of the above-mentioned companies as well as at the office premises of intermediary companies whose accounts were used for diversion of bank funds," a spokesperson for the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) said in a statement. The CBI got a search warrant issued from a special court in Mumbai on Friday.

The searches have led to the seizure of incriminating documents,

'The total quantum of the alleged loss suffered by banks & LIC in these cases is Rs 27,337 crore'

ments, the officials said.

The total quantum of the alleged loss suffered by banks and the LIC in these cases is Rs 27,337 crore, they added.

"Searches have also revealed that multiple intermediary companies were operating from same address. The investigation is continuing," the statement said. The federal agency has lodged seven cases against the Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group based on complaints from various public sector banks and the LIC in connection with alleged frauds involving thousands of crores of rupees.

The CBI had conducted searches at 14 locations in the last few months, immediately after the registration of these cases. The agency has arrested two senior executives of RCom — joint president D Vishwanath, who was the overall in-charge of the group's banking operations, and vice-president Anil Kalya, who had actively supported Vishwanath in managing the banking operations and payments and utilisation of funds — on April 24.

"Both the accused persons are presently in judicial custody. The investigation into the cases relating to the Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group is being monitored by the Supreme Court," the statement said.

Centre operationalises four labour codes, ensures minimum wage and social security

NEW DELHI: After a long wait of over five years, the central government has fully operationalised the four labour codes by publishing rules, ensuring minimum wage and universal social security for all workers.

The four codes, namely the Code on Wages, 2019, the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, the Code on Social Security, 2020, and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020, came into effect from November 21, 2025.

The four codes were introduced to modernise and consolidate 29 labour laws into a simplified and contemporary framework.

An official said that the rules under the four codes are now notified in the official gazette of the government,

and with this, the process of full implementation of the labour codes is complete.

He explained that though the labour codes became law of the land on November 21, 2025, certain explanations were not provided due to the absence of rules.

The draft rules were published on December 30, 2025, to seek feedback from stakeholders and were notified after legal vetting.

The publishing of rules under the four codes was necessary to make the new laws fully operational.

The codification of 29 existing labour laws into the four labour codes was undertaken to address long-standing challenges and make the system more efficient and contemporary.

The codification aims to enhance ease of doing business, promote employment generation, ensure safety, health, and social & wage security for every worker.

Since labour is a concurrent subject, the appropriate governments, the Centre and states, are required to notify the rules under the four codes to enforce them fully across the country.

The enforcement of the codes will mark the next transformative step -- broadening worker protection, easing business operations and promoting a pro-worker labour ecosystem.

The provisions of the labour codes include a mandatory appointment letter, free health check-ups for workers aged 40 years and above, and equal work, pay and opportunity for

women working in different shifts.

The new legal framework also mandates the establishment of a National Reskilling Fund, which will be utilised for reskilling workers who lose their jobs.

The rules also capped the weekly working hours at 48 hours.

"The number of hours of work which shall constitute a normal working day for an employee whose wage period is other than on a daily basis shall be so fixed that the total number of weekly working hours shall not exceed forty-eight hours," according to the rules.

The rules also provide for at least one weekend off or rest day to workers and payment of overtime for working beyond working hours.

Gujarat builds 870 MW battery power backup network to stabilise renewable energy grid

GANDHINAGAR: Gujarat has initiated battery storage systems at five locations in the state, with a total capacity of 870 MW, to maintain the stability of the renewable power grid, officials said on Saturday. Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) are essential for storing electricity generated from solar and other renewable sources. They help manage additional load and maintain grid stability.

"Gujarat has initiated battery storage systems at five locations with a total capacity of 870 MW," an official release stated.

The state has also registered 13 projects across Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar, Banaskantha, Patan and Kutch districts to

set up additional battery storage systems, it said. Modhera in Gujarat, India's first solar village, has launched the country's first BESS integrated with a solar power plant, it said.

"Under the leadership of Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, the state has continued to advance in this direction and has strengthened its position among the leading states driving battery storage systems in India," the release said.

Recently, a battery storage system was commissioned at Charal in the Sanand taluka of Ahmedabad, it said. Four systems are operational at Modhera in Mehsana and Lakhpat in Kutch. The state government



has also included advanced energy storage systems as a key component in the Gujarat Integrated Renewable Energy Policy, 2025, the release said.

Accordingly, standalone battery storage projects, works linked with new renewable energy installations, and those integrated with existing renewable energy systems are being approved, it said.

Once the Standard Operating Procedure is approved, registrations for battery storage will open for commercial and industrial users, it said, adding that the move will allow them to set up battery storage alongside their solar or wind projects.

The state government is developing battery storage systems across Gujarat, with companies being invited in through a competitive bidding process.

GETCO (Gujarat Energy Transmission Corporation) and power distribution companies strategically identify locations for battery storage systems based on grid capacity and operational requirements, the release said.

MUMBAI: Germany is emerging as a preferred higher education destination for Indian students, with around 59,419 Indians currently studying there, reflecting a yearly growth of 25-30 per cent, according to DAAD data. Maharashtra is contributing significantly to this trend, with more students opting for Germany for undergraduate and postgraduate studies across streams such as arts, engineering, management and allied fields.

The rise is being attributed to greater awareness, improved access to German language learning and favourable visa procedures. Germany's appeal is also linked to the availability of around 20,000 courses, strong

India-Germany ties and wider global career opportunities.

Germany-focused higher education consultancy YES Germany has been assisting students across Maharashtra through centres in Andheri, Navi Mumbai, Thane, Baner and Viman Nagar in Pune.

Anuj Deshmukh, Director at YES Germany, said Maharashtra has emerged as a strong market for Germany-focused higher education. He said the consultancy supports around 700-800 students going to Germany annually, with nearly 40 per cent conversions coming from Pune and the remaining 60 per cent from the Mumbai region. Increasing familiarity with the German language has

also contributed to the momentum, he added.

Dr. Latika Chaudhary, CEO of YES Germany, said Germany is becoming increasingly relevant for Maharashtra students due to its combination of academic excellence, affordability, accessibility and career pathways.

Maharashtra also remains the leading destination for German investment in India, accounting for around 49 per cent of German FDI inflows between 2019 & 2024, as per the govt data. The Indo-German Chamber of Commerce, the largest German chamber outside Germany, further highlights the depth of Indo-German economic ties.

Dr AK Panda takes charge as SAIL Chairman and Managing Director

NEW DELHI: Dr. Ashok Kumar Panda on Saturday assumed charge as Chairman & MD of Steel Authority of India Ltd (SAIL). He earlier served as Director (Finance) & held additional charge of Director (Commercial) for about nine months.

Dr. Panda joined SAIL in 1992 as a Management Trainee (Technical) after completing his B.E. in Electrical Engineering. Over more than three decades, he held key roles across various plants and units, gaining experience in operational, financial and commercial functions.



As Director (Finance), he led initiatives to improve operational efficiency and profitability through technical interventions, higher production and

policy revamps across operations, sales and marketing, human resources and finance.

During his tenure as Director (Commercial), he focused on improving volumes, enhancing net sales realisation, reducing inventory and strengthening product branding. After taking charge, Dr. Panda said SAIL will prioritise capacity expansion to 35 MTPA, workplace safety, raw material security and a stronger focus on value-added products and brand growth.

NEW DELHI: Birla Corporation Limited on Saturday reported a consolidated net profit of Rs 294.77 crore in the March quarter of FY26 from Rs 256.6 crore in the corresponding period last year, according to a regulatory filing.

Revenue from operations rose marginally by 0.75 per cent to Rs 2,836.12 crore during the quarter from Rs 2,814.91 crore a year ago.

The company said the performance was impacted by poor realisation in the cement business and external shocks affecting Birla Jute Mills. Total expenses during the quarter stood at Rs 2,522.18 crore, up 1 per cent year-on-year.

Revenue from the cement business increased marginally to Rs 2,716.06 crore in the fourth quarter of FY26 from Rs 2,691.84 crore in the year-ago period. Cement sales volume grew 4 per cent to 5.45

Total expenses in Q4 FY26 stood at Rs 2,522.18 cr, up 1% year-on-year

metric tonnes, the company's highest-ever quarterly sales volume. However, sales realisations remained subdued despite strong demand.

Revenue from the jute division declined 2.63 per cent to Rs 120.14 crore as mills continued to face raw jute shortages and rising prices. Daily production fell to 110 metric tons, down 18 per cent year-on-year and 7 per cent sequentially.

The company said raw jute prices in the March quarter surged 92 per cent year-on-year and 57 per cent sequentially. Total sales in the March quarter dropped 2 per cent year-on-year to Rs 120 crore, while domestic

sales fell 5 per cent.

Total income of the MP Birla Group flagship firm stood almost flat at Rs 2,875.07 crore in the March quarter.

For the full FY26, Birla Corporation's profit surged 88.8 per cent to Rs 557.58 crore, while total consolidated income rose 5 per cent to Rs 9,772.56 crore.

The company said cement sales in FY26 touched a record high of 18.72 MT, with capacity utilisation at 95 per cent.

Heat creeps back, but rain relief awaits city

Rain, thunderstorm alert for Mon, Tue

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The national capital experienced a slight temperature rise, while the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a yellow alert for Monday and Tuesday, warning of possible rain and thunderstorms.

Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a maximum temperature of 36.9 degrees Celsius, which is 0.5 degrees higher than the previous day and 2.4 degrees below normal. The minimum temperature was 23.8 degrees Celsius, marking a 1.2-degree increase from Friday, but still 1.3 degrees below normal.

Similar increases were noted at other weather stations across the city.

Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 35.5 degrees, 1.1 degree more than Friday, and a minimum of 23.4 degree Celsius, 2.7 degree more than a day before; Lodhi Road recorded a maximum of 35.8 degrees, a 1.6 degree rise from a day before and a minimum of 23.2 degrees Celsius, 1.8 degree more than Friday; Ridge recorded a minimum of 21.5 degrees and Ayanagar recorded 23.4 degrees, respectively 1.5 degrees and 2 degrees more than a day before.

The IMD has issued a yellow alert for Monday and Tuesday.

"A fresh western disturbance is likely to affect the western Himalayan region from Sunday. In Delhi, very light to light rainfall, accompa-



People at the Red Fort on Saturday

PTI

Highlights

» The maximum temperature, according to IMD forecast, is expected to be around 37-39 degrees Celsius by Monday, and the minimum temperature is expected to be around 25-27 degrees Celsius.

» The IMD has issued a yellow alert for Monday and Tuesday

nied by thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds of speed 30-40 kmph, even gusting to 50 kmph, is expected on Monday and Tuesday," an IMD official said.

The maximum temperature, according to IMD forecast, is expected to be around

37-39 degrees Celsius by Monday, and the minimum temperature is expected to be around 25-27 degrees Celsius.

The air quality of the city, meanwhile, was in the moderate category, and the 24-hour average air quality index (AQI) was clocked at 116 (moderate) at 4 pm on Saturday, as compared to the 24-hour average AQI of 100 (satisfactory) recorded at the same time on Friday, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

According to CPCB standards, an AQI of 0-50 is considered 'good', 51-100 'satisfactory', 101-200 'moderate', 201-300 'poor', 301-400 'very poor', and 401-500 'severe'.

The Air Quality Early Warning System (AQEWS) for Delhi has forecast the AQI to remain in the moderate category for the next few days.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major administrative reshuffle involving 23 senior IAS and DANICS officers, the Delhi government has posted Navin Kumar Choudhary as Additional Chief Secretary of the General Administration Department.

A services department order issued on Friday said the 1997-batch Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram and Union Territories (AGMUT) cadre IAS officer Sandeep Kumar will be the principal secretary of Public Works Department (PWD), earlier headed by Choudhary.

Vikas Anand (2002 IAS), secretary to the chief minister,

will also serve as Director of the Union Territory Civil Services (UTCS), replacing Bipul Pathak, besides holding the post of Secretary, Information and Publicity department. The reshuffle involved 12 IAS and 11 DANICS (Delhi Andaman & Nicobar Lakshadweep Daman and Diu and Dadra and Nagar Haveli Civil Services) officers.

DANICS officer Prashant Kumar, 2010 batch, holding the charge of Additional Secretary in the Public Grievances Commission under the chief minister's Office, will also hold additional charge of Director of the Directorate of Information and Publicity (DIP), said the order. In other important

changes, Dilraj Kaur (2000 IAS), awaiting posting, has been appointed Managing Director of the Delhi Scheduled Castes Finance and Development Corporation with additional charge of the Delhi Cooperative Housing Finance Corporation.

Nandini Paliwal (2003 IAS) was appointed Secretary (Vigilance) and was also given additional charge of Secretary (Services) and Chairperson of the Delhi Subordinate Services Selection Board (DSSSB). Yashpal Garg (2008) was posted as Secretary (Planning) with additional charge of Secretary (Land and Building) and Development Commissioner.

G Sudhakar (2012 IAS),

district magistrate of Central Delhi, has been posted as director of the Women and Child Development department with additional charge of managing director of the State Urban Livelihoods Mission.

Kishore Kshirasagar Lakshman (2010 IAS) was appointed District Magistrate (Old Delhi), and Yash Chaudhary was posted as Special Secretary (Health).

Cheemala Siva Gopal Reddy (2020 IAS) was appointed Special Secretary to the Lieutenant Governor, while Rajeev Singh was made Member of the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board with additional charge of Special Secretary (Land and Building).

High alert over possible terror threat

NEW DELHI: The national capital is on high alert following intelligence inputs indicating a possible terror threat. This prompted the Delhi Police and other security agencies to intensify vigil across several sensitive locations, sources said on Saturday.

A source said security has been increased at the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) headquarters on Deen Dayal Upadhyaya (DDU) Marg and nearby government establishments, with additional deployment of armed personnel, barricading and intensified vehicle checks.

According to sources, agencies have received alerts regarding possible attempts to target prominent offices and crowded areas in central Delhi using suicide attacks, vehicle-borne improvised explosive devices (IEDs), shootings and coordinated strikes.

Sources said anti-sabotage checks are being carried out at important government buildings, political offices, markets, transport hubs and other crowded places across the city.

Bomb disposal squads, sniffer dog units and quick reaction teams, including the Delhi Fire Service, have also been asked to stay alert. "Police have been directed to maintain strict vigil on suspicious movements, unattended objects and vehicles parked in sensitive zones," said the source.

Security arrangements have also been strengthened at settlements and areas considered vulnerable from a law-and-order perspective; local police are conducting random checking drives and verification exercises. All district units have been instructed to remain alert and maintain close coordination.

MPOST

L-G bats for inclusive urban growth at JNU



Taranjit Singh Sandhu at the event

MPOST

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu outlined a vision for the Capital's future development centred on sustainability, inclusivity, innovation and compassionate governance while addressing an interaction programme at the School of International Studies (SIS), Jawaharlal Nehru University.

The event, organised by SIS to felicitate Sandhu, an alumnus of the institution, focused on the theme "Reimagining Delhi". Speaking at the gathering, the Lieutenant Governor said accountable, accessible and humane governance would form the foundation of a modern and progressive Delhi.

Highlighting key urban challenges confronting the Capital, Sandhu stressed the need for stronger measures to combat air pol-

lution, clean the Yamuna, rejuvenate water bodies and improve waste management systems. He also underlined the importance of sustainable public transport and increasing green cover as essential components of urban development.

The L-G described stability, inclusion, culture, innovation, economic growth and compassion as the "five key pillars" guiding Delhi's future trajectory. He said development policies must ensure equal opportunities and improved living conditions for all sections of society. Vice-Chancellor Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit, who chaired the event, said JNU's academic culture was rooted in the principles of "10 Ds" including democracy, diversity, debate and deliberation. She said the university community took pride in Sandhu's achievements as an SIS alumnus.

NOTICES ISSUED TO 'ILLEGAL' OCCUPANTS Illegal Yamuna floodplain settlements face eviction

NEW DELHI: Eviction notices have been issued to 52 "illegal" occupants residing in unsafe structures within the flood-control boundary wall along Yamuna Bazar ghats, with authorities saying that encroachment on the floodplains poses a serious threat to life, property and public safety.

In a post on X on Saturday, the district magistrate (Old Delhi) said flooding in 2023 and 2025 had prompted large-scale relief operations in the area, putting heavy strain on public resources. "Illegal occupation in Yamuna flood plains (O-Zone) poses a serious threat to life, property and public safety. Repeated flooding in 2023 and 2025 led to large-scale relief operations, putting heavy strain on public resources," the post said.

It further said preventive



action is essential to safeguard human lives and restore the Yamuna floodplains.

The remarks came days after the DDMA issued eviction notices to around 300 "illegal" households in Yamuna Bazar area on May 7, directing them to vacate the encroached floodplain land within 15 days.

According to the notice, an illegal residential cluster comprising around 310 dwellings exists within the flood-control

wall along the Yamuna banks in the O-Zone, a protected no-construction floodplain owned by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

"The same is being inundated during Yamuna floods every year thereby posing a serious threat to the loss of human life, cattle and property," the notice stated.

Invoking powers under Section 34 of the Disaster Management Act, 2005, the DDMA

directed residents occupying the encroached area to remove their belongings and vacate the premises voluntarily within 15 days of issuance of the notice.

It warned that failure to comply would lead to demolition action without further notice.

The action came a week after Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu chaired a review meeting with DDA officials on the progress of rejuvenation works in the Yamuna Bazar area following his visit there, along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, last month.

During the meeting, Sandhu directed officials to ensure robust flood mitigation measures for the low-lying area, which frequently faces waterlogging during the monsoon and disrupts traffic movement along the Ring Road.

AGENCIES

‘Three mule account operators held for routing over Rs 1.22-crore cybercrime proceeds’

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested three persons from Gujarat, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh for allegedly providing mule bank accounts for routing over Rs 1.22-crore proceeds in separate cyber fraud cases involving fake IPO investments, digital arrest and forex trading scams, an official said on Saturday.

Police said the cyber cell and crime branch cracked three cyber fraud cases in which victims were duped through fraudulent financial schemes via social media groups, fake

websites and impersonation.

In the first case, registered on May 30, 2025, a resident of east Delhi's Laxmi Nagar was allegedly cheated of around Rs 46.66 lakh through a fake stock market and IPO scheme.

According to police, the frauds lured the complainant into investing money by displaying fake profits and promising high returns.

During investigation, police traced Rs 6.71 lakh of the cheated amount to a bank account belonging to a Surat-based firm. The authorised

signatory of the account, identified as Rajesh Ratnabhai Hadiya, was arrested from Gujarat.

Police said Hadiya allegedly provided the bank account on commission basis for routing fraudulent online transactions. The account was found linked to three complaints on the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP), including the present case.

In the second case, registered on April 14, the complainant was allegedly kept under prolonged "digital

arrest" by cybercriminals posing as officials of the Mumbai Crime Branch, Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Enforcement Directorate (ED), and Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI).

Police said the accused instilled fear by showing forged FIRs, fake Supreme Court and ED documents, fabricated arrest warrants, and levelling false accusations of money laundering linked to misuse of the complainant's Aadhaar.

"Under fear of arrest, the victim

engineering backgrounds such as Mechanical and Thermal Engineering but are teaching Computer Science and Electronics courses.

The students further objected to the allotment of Damodar Hostel exclusively to engineering students. According to the memorandum, the hostel is located over three kilometres from the Engineering Lecture Complex (ELC), creating commuting difficulties for students, particularly those without access to regular transport. The union also demanded immediate repair of roads near the hostel. Among other demands, JNUSU sought the establishment of a dedicated 24x7 reading room for engineering students and round-the-clock laboratory access for research scholars.

transferred Rs 36.19 lakh into multiple bank accounts provided by the fraudsters," a police officer said.

During investigation, Rs 5.90 lakh was traced to accounts linked to a firm in Rajasthan's Kota. Police arrested Musaveer Khan, who allegedly operated multiple bank accounts through a financial consultancy setup for routing cheated money on commission basis.

The accounts were linked with four NCRP complaints, including the present case, the officer said.

AGENCIES

673 hectares of Central Ridge now reserved forest

‘This decision reflects our commitment towards environmental conservation’

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has granted Reserved Forest status to over 670 hectares of the Central Ridge area under the Indian Forest Act, to strengthen environmental protection, biodiversity conservation and pollution control in the national capital.

According to an official statement issued on Saturday, the notified area falls under the Western Forest Division and covers parts around Sardar Patel Marg and the President's Estate.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision marked a major step towards protecting Delhi's ecologically sensitive Ridge areas, often described as the "green lungs" of the city. "With commitment and

In Short

» The notification would provide stronger statutory protection to the area and help prevent encroachments, illegal activities and ecological degradation

» Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision marked a major step towards protecting



Delhi's ecologically sensitive Ridge areas, often described as the "green lungs" of the city

determination, our government has declared nearly 673.32 hectares of the Central Ridge area as Reserved Forest," Gupta said.

The notification would provide stronger statutory pro-

tection to the area and help prevent encroachments, illegal activities and ecological degradation, she added.

The Reserved Forest status has been granted under Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act,

1927. In the Reserved areas, activities including hunting, grazing, etc, are banned unless specific orders are issued.

This decision reflects our commitment towards environmental conservation, expansion of green cover, and securing a safe and balanced future for the coming generations. The process of granting final legal protection to the Ridge areas had remained pending despite their initial notification in 1994 under Section 4 of the Act, she said, adding that the declaration completed an important process that had been pending for more than three decades.

The Central Ridge stretches along both sides of Upper Ridge Road and forms part of

the ancient Aravalli hill system, the statement said.

Gupta said the Ridge plays a key role in improving air quality, conserving biodiversity, strengthening groundwater levels and mitigating the impact of climate change and urban pollution.

Around 4,080.82 hectares of the Southern Ridge area had been declared a Reserved Forest on October 24 last year, Gupta said, adding that the government is expediting the process of notifying the remaining Ridge areas in Delhi as Reserved Forests.

With the latest notification, a total of 4,754.14 hectares of Ridge areas in Delhi have now been granted Reserved Forest status, she added.

AGENCIES

Two killed as car hits motorcycle in northeast Delhi; offending driver held

NEW DELHI: Two men travelling on a motorcycle were killed after a car allegedly rammed into its rear near Bhajanpura Metro station in northeast Delhi, police said on Saturday.

The driver of the offending vehicle has been arrested, they added.

The accident took place on the intervening night of May 8 and 9 in Khajuri Khas area, when a Maruti Celerio car hit the Bullet motorcycle with two persons -- Rohit (31) and Hemant (33), residents of Karawal Nagar -- onboard, a senior police officer said.

The car allegedly hit the motorcycle from the rear, leaving the two riders seriously injured.

They were shifted to Jag

Police bust IPL ticket black marketing racket, 3 held

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted a black-marketing racket involving Tata IPL match tickets and arrested three people for allegedly selling complimentary passes and regular tickets at exorbitant prices, an official said on Saturday.

The accused have been identified as Mukeem (35), Gufran alias Sajid (36) and Mohammad Faisal (38), police said.

According to police, a team of the crime branch laid a trap near Delhi Gate on May 8 after a tip-off about the illegal sale of IPL tickets.

AGENCIES

Pravesh Chandra Hospital on a PCR van, where doctors declared them dead, the officer said.

"A forensic team inspected the scene and collected evidence. The bodies have been sent for post-mortem. The

accused driver, identified as Himanshu (27) has been arrested and the offending vehicle seized," the police officer said. Further investigation is underway to ascertain the exact sequence of events leading to the accident.

AGENCIES

VICE ADMIRAL SWAMINATHAN TO BE NEW NAVY CHIEF

Pakistan-China expert Lt Gen Subramani named next CDS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Lt Gen NS Raja Subramani (ret'd) has been named India's next Chief of Defence Staff and his primary mandate will be to implement the ambitious military theaterisation plan and bolster tri-services synergy.

The government has also appointed Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan as the next Chief of the Naval Staff.

While Lt Gen Subramani will replace incumbent Gen Anil Chauhan as the country's senior-most military commander, Vice Admiral Swaminathan will succeed Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi as the Navy Chief, according to an official statement.

Widely known as an expert on Pakistan and China, Lt Gen Subramani retired as Vice Chief of Army Staff on July 31 last year and is currently serving as military adviser to the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS).

He will take over as the Chief of Defence Staff on May 30.

Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, presently heading the Western Naval Command, will take charge on May 31. Both Gen Chauhan and Admiral Tripathi are retiring from service.

The government has appointed Lt Gen NS Raja Subramani (Ret'd) as the Chief of Defence Staff and he will also function as the secretary of the department of military affairs, the defence ministry said on Saturday.

As Chief of Defence Staff, Subramani's primary task will be to implement the theaterisation model by rolling out integrated military commands



Lieutenant General NS Raja Subramani has been appointed as next Chief of Defence Staff & Secretary, Department of Military Affairs. He will take charge as next CDS on May 30th



Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan has been appointed as the next Chief of the Naval Staff. He will assume charge on May 31st. He is presently heading the Western Naval Command

Highlights

» Lt Gen Subramani will replace incumbent Gen Anil Chauhan as the country's senior-most military commander

» In his illustrious career spanning over 40 years, he served across a wide spectrum of conflict and terrain profiles and held a host of Command, Staff and Instructional appointments

» Vice Admiral Swaminathan will succeed Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi as the Navy Chief

» Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, presently heading the Western Naval Command

As Chief of Defence Staff, Subramani's primary task will be to implement the theaterisation model by rolling out integrated military commands

ing out integrated military commands.

Gen Chauhan, a former Eastern Army Commander, took charge as the country's senior-most military commander in September 2022, over nine months after the first CDS General Bipin Rawat died in a helicopter crash in Tamil Nadu.

In his illustrious career spanning over 40 years, Lt Gen Subramani served across a wide spectrum of conflict and terrain profiles and held a host of Command, Staff and Instructional appointments.

He served as the Vice Chief of the Army Staff from July 1, 2024, to July 31, 2025, and was General Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Central Com-

mand from March 2023 till June 2024.

The officer is a graduate of the National Defence Academy and the Indian Military Academy.

He was commissioned into the eighth battalion of the Garhwal Rifles on December 14, 1985.

Lt Gen Subramani is an alumnus of the Joint Services Command and Staff College, Bracknell (UK), and the National Defence College, New Delhi.

He holds a Master of Arts degree from King's College, London, and an MPhil in Defence Studies from Madras University.

He commanded the 16 Garhwal Rifles in counter-

insurgency operations in Assam as part of Operation Rhino, the 168 Infantry Brigade in Jammu and Kashmir, and the 17 Mountain Division in the Central Sector during a challenging operational environment.

He also distinguished himself by commanding two corps, including a premier strike corps of the Indian Army on the Western Front. The officer possesses insightful knowledge and a deep understanding of operational dynamics on both the Western and Northern borders, according to the Defence Ministry.

As the Navy Chief, Vice Admiral Swaminathan's focus is likely to be on taking forward the ongoing modernisation of

the force.

The Flag Officer was commissioned into the Indian Navy on July 1, 1987, and is a specialist in communication and electronic warfare.

Swaminathan is an alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakvasla; the Joint Services Command and Staff College, Shrivenham, United Kingdom; the College of Naval Warfare, Karanja; and the US Naval War College, Newport.

A recipient of the Param Vishisht Seva Medal (PVSM), Ati Vishisht Seva Medal (AVSM) and Vishisht Seva Medal (VSM), the Admiral has held several key operational, staff and training appointments in his naval career, including the command of missile vessels INS Vidut and Vinash, the missile corvette INS Kulish, the guided missile destroyer INS Mysore and the aircraft carrier INS Vikramaditya.

Following his promotion to the rank of Vice Admiral, the Flag Officer served as Chief of Staff of the Western Naval Command, Controller of Personnel Services, and Chief of Personnel at Naval Headquarters.

Prior to his current assignment, he served as Vice Chief of the Naval Staff.

Vice Admiral Swaminathan's educational qualifications include a BSc degree from Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi; an MSc in Telecommunications from Cochín University of Science and Technology; and an MA in Defence Studies from King's College, London. He also holds an MPhil in Strategic Studies and a PhD in International Studies, both from Mumbai University.

EU-India partnership 'limitless, ambitious': Ambassador Delphin

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The European Union-India partnership is "limitless, ambitious and progressive" and both sides have elevated the relationship to a "totally new level" in both qualitative and strategic terms, EU Ambassador Herve Delphin has said.

In an address at an event, the envoy also noted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "not an era of war" message "deeply resonates" with Europe's values and identity and called the EU "fundamentally a peace project".

Characterising the EU-India summit held three and a half months ago as a milestone, Delphin said the confluence of symbolism, substance and strategic significance resulted in "momentous outcomes".

"We have placed our relationship to a totally new level, in qualitative and strategic terms. The EU-India partnership is limitless, ambitious and progressive," he said.

"These achievements would not have been possible without the political conviction and trust shared by our leaders," the envoy said at the Europe Day celebrations on Friday night.

The envoy said the India-EU partnership is "truly consequential" for the 21st century and that both sides are determined to significantly expand the ties in diverse sectors.

Delphin cited the unveiling of a joint strategic agenda for the next five years, the conclusion of negotiations for an ambitious free trade agreement, the signing of a security and defence partnership pact and the firming up of a comprehensive framework on mobility as major takeaways from the summit.

"Fundamentally, we are global forces for good. We are both recognised as trusted, reliable partners working for global stability and prosperity, promoting global cooperation and solutions," he said.



EU Ambassador to India Herve Delphin, left, and MEA Joint Secretary Priyanka Chauhan during the first meeting of the Joint Steering Committee (JSC) for India-EU Trilateral Cooperation, in New Delhi

'We have placed our relationship to a totally new level, in qualitative and strategic terms. The EU-India partnership is limitless, ambitious and progressive'

and solutions," he said.

"That India and the EU and its member states are deepening their ties like never before is truly a reason for celebration this year. This is the Europe-India moment," Delphin said in the presence of Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and a sizeable number of diplomats, academicians and foreign policy experts.

The envoy characterised the presence of European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President Antonio Costa as the chief guests at India's Republic Day parade and the EU-India summit as a "moment where symbolism, substance and strategic significance came together, resulting in momentous outcomes".

The free trade agreement

between the two sides has been billed as the "mother of all" trade deals. "We are already India's leading trading partner. With the FTA in place, we expect our two-way trade to double in value in the next years," Delphin said.

The envoy also cited a report titled the "EU business economic footprint in India" released this week that analysed various dimensions of the two-way economic engagement.

"About 6000 EU companies, generating the creation of close to six million jobs, exporting close to 25 billion euro from India to the world (6 per cent of India's total exports)," he said.

The EU, as a bloc, is India's largest trading partner in goods. For the financial year 2024-25, India's total trade in goods with the EU was worth about \$136 billion, with exports around \$76 billion and imports at \$60 billion. In his remarks, Delphin also mentioned what he described as Russia's "war of aggression" against Ukraine.

"Wars cause immense human suffering, massive economic losses. Ultimately, aggressors end up paying the higher price. Russia is not winning but losing the war of aggression it deliberately launched," he said.

From Page 1

Bengal's 9th, BJP's 1st CM: Suvendu takes oath

PM Modi, Union Home minister Amit Shah and others shared the stage before a sea of saffron flags and chants of "Jai Shri Ram".

As PM Modi walked onto the stage, he bent low, touched his forehead to the dais with folded hands and acknowledged the crowd, triggering thunderous applause from lakhs of BJP supporters packed into Brigade. The PM greeted Makhanlal Sarkar, 98, who had accompanied Shyama Prasad Mukherjee during his last mission to Kashmir, opposing the now-shelved special status, to the erstwhile state.

Soon after taking over as the new chief minister, Suvendu Adhikari went to Jorasanko Thakurbari, the residence of Rabindranath Tagore. "Without Rabindranath Tagore, you can't think about Bengali culture. We started a new era by paying tribute to Tagore on his birth anniversary," said Adhikari.

After taking the oath, Suvendu also said his government would propose observing "West Bengal Day" on June 20 instead of Poila Baisakh, the Bengali New Year's Day chosen by his predecessor, Mamata Banerjee.

Asserting that the date marked the historic decision for West Bengal's inclusion in India in 1947, Adhikari told reporters: "I will definitely place this proposal before the cabinet and the Assembly.

On June 20, 1947, MLAs from West Bengal voted for partition, after a joint meeting with MLAs from East Bengal (which became East Pakistan) voted against the partition of the state.

Adhikari's parents could not attend the swearing-in ceremony as they are unwell. Suvendu's father, Sisir Adhikari, said: "He is my second son among four. From childhood, he has shown leadership qualities, and he is a chief ministerial material. He is a composed and very good organiser as well."

Adhikari's mother, Gayatri Devi, said: "He is always very cool. I never scolded him as he was never naughty."

She added: "Suvendu loves fried fish, especially Hilsa." She wants her son to work toward achieving justice for the RG Kar Medical College and Hospital rape-murder victim.

"I will ask him to now work for achieving justice to the R G Kar rape-murder victim and all others who faced atrocities," she added.

After paying his tribute at Jorasanko Thakurbari, Adhikari held a meeting with the top government officials. Later in the evening, he paid a visit to the ancestral house of Dr Shyama Prasad Mukherjee. He also visited the Kalighat Temple and offered puja.

The Prime Minister congratulated Suvendu Adhikari as West Bengal's first BJP Chief Minister, saying he was "deeply connected to the people and understood their aspirations". In his message for Suvendu Adhikari on X, PM Modi wished him a 'fruitful tenure'.

Union Home minister Amit Shah, the BJP's central leadership and chief ministers of NDA-ruled states were present at the swearing-in ceremony.

"Congratulations to Dilip Ghosh Ji, Agnimitra Paul Ji, Ashok Kirtania Ji, Kshudiram Tudu Ji and Nisith Pramanik Ji on taking oath as Ministers in the Government of West Bengal. These leaders have worked tirelessly at the grassroots and served people. I am confident they will further strengthen West Bengal's development journey as Ministers. My best wishes," Modi wrote on X.

I am CM now, and I belong to everybody, says Suvendu

We have to set the record straight and bring the state back on the path of glory," he added. Meanwhile, Adhikari will hold his government's first administrative meeting on May 11, officials said.

Superintendents of police and senior officials of all districts will take part in that meeting, the first one of the state's maiden BJP government, during which law and order and administrative preparedness will be discussed.

The first Cabinet meeting of the government is also likely to be held in the latter half of next week, officials reportedly said.

After taking the oath of office on Saturday, Adhikari held a meeting with Chief Secretary Dushyant Nariyal, Director General of Police Siddh Nath Gupta, and a few police and civil officials to review the law and order situation in the state.

Kolkata Police Commissioner Ajay Nand was also present at the meeting, sources said.

Addressing the media at Jorasanko earlier in the day, Suvendu reiterated his commitment to rebuilding the state and prioritising progress over political blame or criticism.

Emphasising the responsibility entrusted to him by the people, he said that while significant damage has been done across sectors, it is now time to move forward and focus on delivery and performance.

"Let us rebuild Bengal. Bengal has seen enough damage. Education is lost, culture has been destroyed, and we will rebuild Bengal," he said.

The CM added that the moment marked the beginning of a new chapter for the state. "I am the Chief Minister now, and I belong to everybody. We have been entrusted with a lot of responsibilities. This is not the time for criticism," he said adding "May they be awakened who are still criticising and discussing the election results." Adhikari also stated that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had wished for such a day and described the occasion as historic for West Bengal.

"There is a huge responsibility on our shoulders. Those who are still criticising, let them do it, but I will only move ahead," he further pointed out. Dressed in a traditional dhoti and saffron panjabi, Adhikari said he wanted to seek the blessings of "Kaviguru" Rabindranath Tagore before starting his work as the CM. "My official

work begins after paying tribute to Kaviguru," he said during the visit.

Invoking the teachings of Swami Vivekananda, Adhikari referred to the phrase "Charaiveti, Charaiveti" meaning "keep moving forward" and urged people to work together for the development of a "new Bengal".

Suvendu leads new Cabinet with 5 ministers...

A year later, she became the state president of Mahila Morcha, succeeding Locket Chatterjee. In 2021, she was appointed the General Secretary of the BJP in Bengal. A two-time MLA from Asansol Dakshin and BJP's Bengal vice-president, Paul emerged as one of the party's key women leaders during the 2026 Assembly election campaign.

Nisith Pramanik, belonging to the Rajbongshi community, is one of the BJP's prominent young leaders from North Bengal. In July 2021, he was appointed Minister of State for Home Affairs and Minister of State for Youth Affairs and Sports in the Narendra Modi government, becoming one of the youngest ministers at the age of 35.

Ashok Kirtania is from the Matua community, who represents Bangaon Uttar in North 24-Parganas, an area strongly influenced by Matua politics in West Bengal. He has worked in business and has also been active in local organisational politics.

Kshudiram Tudu is a tribal leader from Bankura, representing Ranibandh, a tribal-dominated constituency in the Jangalmahal region. BJP has relied on leaders like him to strengthen its outreach among tribal communities in West Bengal.

Modi bows to Bengal's 'jana shakti'

He also shared a video clip of the moment on his social media page.

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The PM also took the blessing of 98-year-old Makhanlal Sarkar at the swearing-in ceremony. Sarkar, a devout nationalist, worked with Dr

Syama Prasad Mookerjee and was even arrested in Jammu and Kashmir while accompanying him.

He also paid tribute to the BJP karyakartas who sacrificed their lives. "A tribute to the courageous BJP Karyakartas! Even in the midst of celebrations at the Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata today on the formation of the first ever BJP Government in West Bengal, we remembered all those BJP Karyakartas who laid down their lives in the service of an ideal greater than themselves. Their sacrifice is etched forever in the journey of the Party. Their courage will remain a source of strength for all of us," he wrote on his X handle.

The Prime Minister also remembered all those BJP workers who sacrificed their lives to uphold their ideals.

"Their self-sacrifice remains eternally memorable in the party's onward march. Their courage will continue to be a source of strength for all of us," he wrote.

Following the swearing-in ceremony, PM Modi met the families of slain BJP workers Debashish Mondal, Soumitra Ghoshal and Ananda Paul.

In a pleasant coincidence, the oath-taking ceremony of the first-ever BJP Government in West Bengal took place on Pochishe Boishakh, the Jayanti of Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore. At the ceremony, tributes were paid to Gurudev Tagore.

TN: 120 reasons for Vijay to smile

Katchi (VCK) and the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) on Saturday. Later, he headed to the Lok Bhavan for his fourth meeting with Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar in as many days to discuss government formation, before the latter appointed Vijay as CM and invited him to form the ministry.

TVK workers burst firecrackers and distributed sweets and gathered in large numbers in the party office to celebrate.

The VCK and IUML extended "unconditional support," to Vijay-led Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam.

DMK's allies including the VCK have made it clear that they continue to be part of the Dravidian party led alliance.

Quickly after the VCK and IUML gave to TVK, letters of support addressed to the governor, Vijay went to the Lok Bhavan along with leaders from ally Congress,

and supporting parties including the Left and VCK handed over the letters to Arlekar.

Parties including VCK will not be part of the government and they offer "outside support". After deliberations, Arlekar presented to Vijay a letter appointing him as the chief minister and asked him to form the government, a Lok Bhavan press release said.

Vijay called on the Governor at Lok Bhavan and submitted a letter informing about his election as the leader of the Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam Legislature party.

He has also submitted letters received from the Congress, CPI, CPI-M, VCK and IUML extending their support to form the government under his leadership.

The governor accepting Vijay's claim to form government, appointed him as the CM as per the Constitutional norms and asked him to form the ministry. He also asked the TVK chief to face the vote of confidence on or before May 13.

The suspense over government formation ended when the Thol.Thirumavalavan-led VCK, which has two seats, finally extended support after keeping the TVK on tenterhooks and the political circles abuzz over its stand over the last two days.

VCK, a long time ally of the Left parties who had extended their support to Vijay on Friday, had earlier announced its decision would be in sync with their stand.

Shortly after VCK's decision to back Vijay, another DMK ally, the IUML also extended support to TVK. The IUML has two MLAs.

While it was expected that the VCK would announce its stand on Saturday morning, the party revealed its decision later in the day. There were unverified reports of some hard-bargaining between TVK and VCK, possibly over ministerial allocations, but there was no official confirmation from either side.

Vijay, however, has been open to accommodate allies in his cabinet, in sync with VCK's stated position of power-sharing.

With the two small parties' support, the numbers in favour of TVK rose to 120, just two more than the simple majority mark of 118 in the 234-member Tamil Nadu Assembly.

The Vijay-led TVK also faced serious allegations when NDA constituent AMMK accused it of alleged bid aimed at horse-trading. MLAs belonging to Congress, which has extended support to the TVK, have shifted to Hyderabad.

The drama over government formation also witnessed the return of "resort politics" -- last seen in Tamil Nadu after the demise of AIADMK matriarch and Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa in 2016, the five Congress MLAs were now in Hyderabad and TVK legislators were in a resort/hotel in Mamallapuram near here. While the AIADMK MLAs have returned to Chennai from Puducherry, its chief Edappadi K Palaniswami has greeted the "party that is set to form the government".

The AMMK accused the TVK of allegedly using a "forged" support letter from its lone MLA to stake claim for government formation and also alleged horse-trading attempt and the party has lodged a police complaint. The TVK dismissed the allegations as "false news," releasing a counter-video purportedly showing MLA Kamaraj signing the "support letter" voluntarily.

Vijay-led Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam, with 108 seats, but 10 short of a majority initially, had earlier reached out to the Congress, CPI, CPI (M), VCK and IUML -- all DMK allies, seeking their support to form the government after winning its maiden Assembly election in Tamil Nadu, which was held on April 23. The results were declared on May 4.

Vijay, who has won from two segments, Perambur in Chennai and Tiruchirappalli East, He has to resign from one of them, bringing down the party's strength to 107. The number of MLAs from parties supporting the TVK -- Congress (5) and the CPI, CPI (M), VCK and IUML with two MLAs each, stands at 13.

The Congress has broken ties with DMK but the others have said they continue in the Dravidian-party lead alliance.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

MODI TO VISIT K'TAKA, T'GANA, GUJARAT ON MAY 10-11

PM: Govt’s social security schemes ensure ‘dignity & financial security’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said his government's social security schemes reflect its commitment to bring dignity, assurance and financial security into the lives of the people of India.

Modi said that on this day, 11 years ago, key social security and pension schemes were launched by the NDA government. “They reflect our commitment to bring dignity, assurance and financial security into the lives of the people of India,” he said in a post on X.

The prime minister said the PM Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and PM Suraksha Bima Yojana have had a positive impact at the grassroots.

Launched on May 9, 2015, by the prime minister, the Jansuraksha schemes- Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima



CLOSER LOOK

» Prime Minister Modi said that on this day, 11 years ago, key social security and pension schemes were launched by the NDA govt

» He said the PM Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and PM Suraksha Bima Yojana have had a positive impact at the grassroots

Yojana (PMJJBY), Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY) were envisioned to extend affordable financial protection to all, particularly the underserved and vulnerable sections of society.

These flagship schemes aim to broaden the insurance and pension landscape by shielding citizens against life's uncertainties and fostering long-term financial resilience.

PM to visit Karnataka, Telangana, Gujarat on May 10-11

PM Modi will visit Karnataka, Telangana and Gujarat on May 10 and 11, during which he will inaugurate and dedicate projects worth around Rs 9,400 crore in Hyderabad and also participate in the Somnath Amrut Mahotsav at Somnath temple. He will also participate in the 45th anniversary celebrations of The Art of Living in Bengaluru and inaugurate and lay the foundation stone of multiple projects in Telangana, two official statements said.

On Sunday morning, the prime minister will participate in the anniversary celebrations in Bengaluru and address the gathering. He will inaugurate the newly constructed Dhyana Mandir at the Art of Living International Centre in Bengaluru.

He will then travel to Hyderabad and will lay the foundation stone, inaugurate and dedicate to the nation multiple development projects worth around Rs 9,400 crore.

Mann says no question of withdrawing anti-sacrilege law in Punjab

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday asserted that the anti-sacrilege law will neither be withdrawn nor diluted, claiming it has garnered overwhelming backing from the ‘Sangat’ across the world.

Mann reiterated that the Punjab government remained fully committed to protecting the sanctity and respect of Sri Guru Granth Sahib and all religious scriptures.

The Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Bill, 2026 was unanimously passed by Punjab Assembly on April 13. It has the provision of stricter punishment, including life imprisonment for any act of sacrilege against the Guru Granth Sahib.

Mann on Wednesday started a four-day ‘Shukrana Yatra’ after implementation of the anti-sacrilege law which concluded on Saturday.

He had embarked on the ‘Shukrana Yatra’ on Wednesday with religious fervour after paying obeisance at Takht Sri Kesgarh Sahib in Sri Anandpur Sahib.

Mann said the recently enacted anti-sacrilege law was introduced solely to ensure strict punishment for those attempting to hurt religious sentiments and disturb peace.

The law has received overwhelming support from the Sangat across the world, he said. In a veiled attack on the Badals, he alleged that only “one particular family” was opposing the legislation.

“Those claiming that the

Panth has rejected this law must explain why millions are supporting it,” he asserted, adding that certain vested political interests were trying to mislead people for narrow gains and create unnecessary confusion around the legislation.

Making his government's position clear, the CM asserted that the anti-sacrilege law had already come into force after due constitutional process.

“The Governor has granted assent to the Act. There is no question of withdrawing or rolling back this law,” he said.

Mann stated that the legislation was enacted after a long-standing public demand and there could be no compromise on protecting the sanctity of Sri Guru Granth Sahib.

The CM further pointed out that protests and demonstrations had continued for nearly one-and-a-half years demanding a stricter anti-sacrilege law. He noted that some Sikh intellectuals and scholars opposing the law today had themselves earlier demanded stringent legislation against sacrilege incidents.

He also recalled that in July 2007, the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) had itself passed a resolution authorising the government to enact legislation for the protection and respect of Sri Guru Granth Sahib.

Questioning the opposition's changing stand, Mann asked how those who had earlier supported legislative intervention were now claiming that the government could not enact such a law.

Mamata urges Oppn parties to form ‘joint platform’ against BJP

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Trinamool Congress (TMC) chairperson Mamata Banerjee on Saturday called for the formation of a ‘united platform’ of all political parties that are against the BJP. Along with the national parties, she urged the Leftists and the ultra-Leftists to unite in Bengal as well as in Delhi to fight the BJP which came to power in Bengal after the recently held assembly elections.

“If any political party wants to speak to me in this regard, I am available to discuss the matter. It needs to be remembered that our first enemy is the BJP. They [BJP] want to destroy the country and Bengal,” said Banerjee while addressing a gathering inside her Kalighat residence, while observing Rabindranath Tagore's birth anniversary. The former Bengal chief minister also called upon the student unions of various affiliations opposed to the BJP

‘I would urge the NGOs and other neutral platforms to join this movement as well. All national leaders of the Opposition have contacted me’

and the NGOs to unite against the saffron camp.

“I would urge the NGOs and other neutral platforms to join this movement as well. All national leaders of the opposition have contacted me,” said Banerjee. She added that she has spoken to Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge, Uddhav Thackeray and Tejashwi Yadav.

“Akhilesh Yadav himself came here (her Kalighat residence). I have also spoken to Hemant Soren and Arvind Kejriwal,” she said.

Banerjee alleged that the BJP men were torturing the people of Bengal with the help of goons who had come from other states. “Some goons created trouble in front of my house and Abhishek's residence. Abhishek's daughter is also being threatened. Her private tutor has been heckled,” claimed Banerjee.

She asserted that many people, particularly TMC workers, have been tortured and have been driven out of their homes as well.

“We will help these families through ‘21st July Benevolent Fund.’ I would urge Kalyan Banerjee to look after the legalities. Once that is done, you can contribute as per your will,” she maintained. Banerjee made it clear that she is well aware that people with business interests will not be on her party's side.

“They will align themselves with those who are in power. The door is open for those who want to leave,” she added.

Sravanthi case: ED arrests Punjab Min Sanjeev Arora

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested Punjab Industries Minister Sanjeev Arora in connection with an ongoing money laundering investigation linked to alleged financial irregularities involving the Sravanthi Group and its promoter Dandamudi Venkateswara Rao, popularly known as D.V. Rao.

Officials cite suspicious transactions moving through shell entities. One individual at the centre of the review is a real estate figure using offshore

channels. Inquiry documents reference layered fund movements resembling past cases.

Arrest comes after weeks of witness interviews and digital trail analysis. Agency officials confirm detention under anti-money laundering statutes. The case includes links to infrastructure contracts awarded without standard oversight. Monitoring continues on related accounts flagged during audit sweeps.

The investigation revealed a suspected money movement scheme worth about Rs 284 crore, according to the agency. Besides Arora, authorities took

into custody D.V. Rao, linked to Sravanthi Group, along with company official D. Shanthi Kiran and Rao's sibling, D. Avandira Kumar. Held by a designated judicial body, the individuals will re-main under ED supervision until May 12.

From ED's perspective, scrutiny began with a banking misconduct report filed in Gurugram linked to DJW Electric Power Projects Pvt. Ltd, operated under D.V. Rao. Though originating as a loan inquiry, suspicions arose when ap-proximately Rs 58 crore meant for repayment vanished

India successfully test-fires ‘advanced’ Agni missile

MPOST BUREAU

New Delhi: India has successfully test-fired an Advanced Agni missile with the strategic ability to deploy multiple payloads to separate targets simultaneously -- a milestone that places the country among a select league of global powers.

The testing of the missile with Multiple Independently Targeted Re-Entry Vehicle (MIRV) system was carried out from Odisha's APJ Abdul Kalam Island on Friday, according to the defence ministry.

The MIRV feature ensures that a single missile can deploy multiple war heads at different locations simultaneously.

While the ministry said the flight test of an advanced Agni missile with MIRV was carried out, authoritative sources said it was an Agni-5 missile and the trial was conducted to check the MIRV technology under ‘Mission Divyatra’.

The maiden trial of the Agni-5 with MIRV was carried out in March last year.



“India conducted the successful flight-trial of an advanced Agni missile with Multiple Independently Targeted Re-Entry Vehicle (MIRV) system from Dr APJ Abdul Kalam Island, Odisha on May 8,” the defence ministry said.

“The missile was flight-tested with multiple payloads, targeted to different targets spatially distributed over a large geographical area in the Indian Ocean Region,” it said.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh has complimented the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), Indian Army, and the concerned industry part-

ners on the successful flight-test of the missile. This will add an incredible capability to the country's defence preparedness against the growing threat perceptions, he said.

The ministry said the telemetry and tracking was carried out by multiple ground and ship-based stations.

“These systems tracked the entire missile trajectory from lift-off till the impact of all payloads. Flight data confirmed that all mission objectives were met during the trial,” it said.

“With this successful trial, India once again demonstrated the capability to target multiple strategic targets using a single missile system,” the ministry said in a statement.

The missile is developed by DRDO laboratories with the support of industries. The trial was witnessed by senior scientists of DRDO and the Indian Army personnel.

Agni-5 missile has a range of up to 5,000 km. The Agni 1 to 4 missiles have ranges from 700 km to 3,500 km and they have already been deployed.

Hampton Sky Realty defends Sanjeev Arora, rejects ED allegations

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Hampton Sky Realty Limited, formerly known as Ritesh Properties and Industries Limited, on Saturday defended Punjab Industries Minister Sanjeev Arora and rejected allegations linked to the Enforcement Directorate's ongoing probe, asserting that all export transactions were conducted through authorised legal and regulatory channels.

In a detailed statement, the company said its mobile device export operations, launched in May 2023, complied with government-backed manufacturing and export promotion frameworks. It stated that shipments totalling 44,471 units — including Apple iPhones, AirPods, Samsung and OnePlus devices — were mainly exported to the UAE after passing customs scrutiny, IMEI verification through ICEGATE, approvals from original equipment manufacturers and UAE customs clearance.

The firm claimed activation logs confirmed the devices were switched on outside India, dismissing allegations of fake exports or money laundering. Hampton Sky Realty also denied offshore dealings or hidden accounts, saying all payments moved through official banking channels.

It added that GST-related disputes involving certain vendors are under appellate review and that the company continues to cooperate fully with authorities.



₹2 lakh loan under the scheme helped her start a construction material business by purchasing shuttering plates. Over time, she expanded the business to nearly 1,700 square feet of material and contributed to building over 22 houses, earning an annual income of ₹2.5 lakh to ₹3 lakh.

Sai said empowering women economically strengthens families and society, while the visit underscored the growing impact of women-led self-help groups in remote tribal regions of Chhattisgarh.

RAIPUR: A Jan Chaupal held under a mango tree in the forested interiors of Kabirdham district became a powerful symbol of women's empowerment as Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai interacted with members of self-help groups during his visit to Kamrakhol village under the Sushasan Tihar programme.

The women spoke about their journey from financial hardship to economic independence through livelihood initiatives under the Bihan scheme. Listening to their experiences, the Chief Minister praised their determination and urged them to aim higher. “You have changed your lives through hard work and confidence. Don't stop here. Now dream of becoming ‘Crorepati Didis,’” he told the gathering, drawing applause from villagers.

Among those present was Smt. Kachra Telgam of Kukdoor village, who shared how a

CSIR-IIIM, JKEDI join hands to boost startup ecosystem in J&K

NEW DELHI: The CSIR-Indian Institute of Integrative Medicine (IIIM), Jammu, through its Technology Business Incubator (IIIM-TBI), has signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Jammu and Kashmir Entrepreneurship Development Institute (JKEDI).

The pact seeks to promote entrepreneurship, skill development and startup incubation by drawing on the institutional strengths of both organisations, while also creating a framework for capacity building and market linkages. Speaking at the signing, Dr Zabeer Ahmed, Director CSIR-IIIM Jammu and Chairman IIIM-TBI, said the collaboration “must go beyond paperwork and reflect visible impact” on the ground, and called for a structured action plan with a defined activity calendar and clear responsibilities.

He added that even a modest number of successful startups would mark meaningful progress, urging the identification of sector-specific opportunities and targeted training programmes.

MP Police draws up massive crowd and Railway management blueprint

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh Police has launched large-scale preparations for Simhastha 2028, with senior cops, railway and administrative officials meeting in Bhopal to chalk out plans for crowd management, rail operations and security for the mega religious congregation expected to attract nearly 30 crore devotees.

The meeting, held here, focused on lessons learnt from the Prayagraj Mahakumbh 2025 and the use of modern technology, integrated command systems and scientific crowd assessment mechanisms for the smooth conduct of the month-long event in Ujjain.

Director General of Police (DGP) Kailash Makwana said coordinated planning among the state police, Government Railway Police (GRP), Railway Protection Force (RPF), railways and district administration was crucial in view of the expected surge in pilgrim footfall during Simhastha. He stressed the need for a joint control room, sepa-



HIGHLIGHTS

- » AI-based crowd, security monitoring planned
- » 30 crore devotees expected
- » Rlys to run 3x more special trains

rate entry and exit routes at stations and holding areas, and the avoidance of last-minute platform changes to prevent chaos.

Officials discussed upgrading infrastructure at railway stations in Ujjain, Indore, Ratlam, Bhopal, Omkareshwar Road and Sehore, including wider foot overbridges, better announcement systems, improved signage and additional trains.

The DGP directed GRP and RPF officials to intensify intelligence gathering, ensure extensive CCTV surveillance at stations, parking areas, and holding zones, and maintain rapid-response teams to handle emergencies.

Sharing lessons from the Prayagraj Mahakumbh, UP DG (Railways) Prakash D stressed accurate crowd assessment,

multi-layered crowd management and real-time monitoring through ICCCs, along with colour-coded signage, separate entry-exit routes and digital coordination systems.

RPF DG Sonali Mishra stressed seamless coordination among Western, West Central and Central Railway zones, along with joint training, NDRF coordination and stronger intelligence systems to handle disruptions effectively.

Ratlam DRM Ashwini Kumar said railways are preparing a detailed operational plan based on expected passenger movement and crowd density, with focus on infrastructure expansion and better interconnectivity in coordination with the administration.

Presenting the Ujjain plan,

SP Pradeep Sharma said Simhastha 2028, proposed from April 9 to May 8, is expected to draw nearly five crore devotees on major ‘Shahi Snan’ days, with the fair spread across 3,100 hectares and ghats expanded up to 37 km.

Officials said railways plan to run three times more special trains than during the previous Simhastha, along with short-distance mela trains, dynamic timetables, double-headed operations and planned diversions for long-distance services.

The meeting also decided to deploy AI-based crowd monitoring systems, strengthen cyber security and public address systems, and ensure the availability of medical teams and rapid action units at all major stations and congregation points.

Suvendu aide murder: Attackers had prior input on Rath's position in car

KOLKATA: The SIT probing into the murder of Chandranath Rath, a close aide of BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari found that the assailants had prior information about Rath's position inside the vehicle while he was returning home on Wednesday night, police sources said on Saturday.

Three people have been detained in connection with the killing and are being questioned, police said, adding that no arrests have been made so far.

Investigators suspect that bike-borne gunmen brought in from outside West Bengal executed the attack with precise planning, taking barely 45 to 50 seconds to shoot Rath dead in his car on a busy road in Madhyamgram in North 24-Parganas district. “It appears that the shooters knew exactly where the target was seated inside the vehicle. The execution was swift and professionally coordinated,” a senior SIT officer reportedly said.

‘Somnath Swabhiman Parv’ to be celebrated across Haryana on May 11

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: — The Haryana government will organise Somnath Swabhiman Parv – 1000 Years of Unbroken Faith programmes across the State on May 11, 2026.

The event will be dedicated to India's Sanatan culture, faith, self-respect and glorious civilisation heritage.

Haryana Chief Minister, Nayab Singh Saini, Union ministers, State ministers and MPs will attend the programmes being organised in different districts as chief guests.

The objective of the programme is to connect the younger generation with the country's cultural heritage, Sanatan traditions and the glorious history of the Somnath Temple. The event symbolises India's unwavering faith and self-respect, which has kept its cultural consciousness alive despite numerous challenges over the centuries.

Under the programme, Chief Minister, Nayab Singh Saini will attend the event in Kurukshetra, Union minister

of State, Rao Inderjit Singh in Nuh, Union minister of State, Krishan Pal Gurjar in Faridabad, Speaker Haryana Vidhan Sabha, Harvinder Kalyan in Karnal, Deputy Speaker Dr. Krishan Lal Middha in Jind, Energy minister, Anil Vij in Ambala, Development and Panchayats minister, Krishan Lal Panwar in Sonapat, and Industries and Commerce Minister, Rao Narbir Singh in Gurugram as chief guests.

Similarly, Education minister, Mahipal Dhanda will attend the programme in Panipat, Revenue minister, Vipul Goel in Panchkula, Cooperation minister Dr. Arvind Kumar Sharma in Rohtak, Agriculture Minister, Shyam Singh Rana in Yamunanagar, Public Health Engineering Minister Ranbir Singh Gangwa in Sirsa, Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Krishan Kumar Bedi in Hisar, Women and Child Development Minister, Shruti Choudhry in Bhiwani, Health Minister Aarti Singh Rao in Mahendragarh, and Sports Minister Gaurav Gautam in Palwal as chief guests.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sahil, S/o Santram R/o H.No.323, Village-Neelwal, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.41/26 dated 22.01.2026 u/s 110/126(2)/351(2)/324(4)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sahil** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sahil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sahil of FIR No.41/26 dated 22.01.2026 u/s 110/126(2)/351(2)/324(4)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.07.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Ankit Solanki
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class (North)
Room No.06, First Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/6108/ON/2026

Hungary's Peter Magyar set to be sworn in as PM



BUDAPEST: Hungary's incoming prime minister, Peter Magyar, arrived Saturday at the Parliament building to be sworn into office, ending Viktor Orban's autocratic 16-year rule.

Magyar's center-right Tisza party defeated Orban's nationalist-populist Fidesz in a stunning blow last month, gaining more votes and seats in Parliament than any other party in Hungary's post-Communist history. The win will allow Tisza to roll back many of the policies that gave Orban a reputation among many of his critics as a far-right authoritarian, clamp down on alleged corruption and transform political dynamics within the European Union, where the former prime minister had upended the bloc by frequently vetoing key decisions.

On Saturday, Magyar entered the sprawling neo-Gothic parliament building alongside 140 of his party representatives, controlling 141 seats in Hungary's 199-seat parliament. Orban's Fidesz-KDNP coalition will control 52 seats, down from 135, while the far-right Mi Hazank (Our Homeland) party will hold six seats.

When the inaugural session is held later Saturday, Orban will not join in for the first time since Hungary's first post-Communist Parliament was formed in 1990. After his loss, Orban said he would focus on rebuilding his nationalist-populist political community.

Magyar, a 45-year-old lawyer who founded Tisza in 2024 after years as an insider in Orban's party, has vowed to end official corruption, which he argues has robbed Hungarians of economic opportunity.

WEST ASIA CRISIS

'Ceasefire' holds as US awaits Iran response, Bahrain detains dozens

DUBAI: A tenuous ceasefire appeared to be holding Saturday after the US struck two Iranian oil tankers, while the country that hosts the US Navy's regional headquarters said it arrested dozens of people it alleged were linked to Iran's Revolutionary Guard.

Attacks on Friday cast doubt on the tenuous month-old ceasefire that the United States has insisted is still in effect. Washington is awaiting an Iranian response to its latest proposal for a deal to end the war, reopen the Strait of Hormuz and roll back Tehran's disputed nuclear program.

The US military said Friday that its forces had disabled two Iranian tankers that were trying to breach an American blockade of Iran's ports. Hours earlier, the military said it thwarted attacks on three Navy ships and struck Iranian military facilities



Oil tankers sit at anchor offshore in the Strait of Hormuz on May 2 AP

in the strait. Meanwhile, in the small Gulf island of Bahrain, the nation's Ministry of Interior said it had arrested 41 people it alleges are part of a group affiliated with Iran's Revolutionary Guard. It said investigations are ongoing to take further action against anyone affiliated with the group but did not provide further details.

Bahrain is led by a Sunni Muslim monarchy but, like Iran,

its population is majority Shiite. Rights groups have said that the kingdom has used the war between Iran and the US, which bases its Fifth Fleet in the country, as an excuse to crack down on dissent at home.

Iran has mostly blocked the critical waterway for global energy since the US and Israel launched the war on February 28, causing a global spike in fuel prices and rattling world

'Indian sailor killed in dhow fire near Strait of Hormuz'

NEW DELHI: An Indian sailor was killed and several others injured after their wooden dhow caught fire near the Strait of Hormuz, government sources said on Saturday.

Seventeen other Indian crew members were rescued following the incident on Friday, they said, noting that the exact cause of the blaze is still being ascertained. The crew members were rescued by a vessel which was passing by in the area, the sources said.

"A wooden Dhow, carrying general cargo, with 18 Indian

crew capsized yesterday close to the Strait of Hormuz after it caught fire," said a source.

"In this incident, one Indian on the dhow died while four received burn injuries. The injured are receiving medical treatment in Dubai and are safe," the source said.

Officials from the Indian Consulate in Dubai met the rescued Indian nationals last night, said another source.

The consulate is also in touch with the dhow owner and is extending all possible assistance, they said.

markets. The US has imposed its own blockade of Iran's ports. The US military posted video of

the two Iranian tankers as their smokestacks were struck by an fighter jet on Friday.

Moscow marks Victory Day with 'scaled down' parade

MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin on Saturday voiced confidence of victory in Ukraine as he oversaw a military parade on Red Square commemorating the defeat of Nazi Germany in World War II — a show that didn't include heavy weapons for the first time in nearly two decades.

Security was tight in Moscow as Putin and several foreign leaders attended the parade, which was scaled down even as a US-brokered three-day ceasefire eased concerns about possible Ukrainian attempts to disrupt the festivities.

Putin, in power for more than a quarter-century, has used Victory Day, Russia's most important secular holiday, to showcase the country's military might and rally support for his military action in Ukraine, now in its fifth year.

Speaking at the parade, Putin hailed Russian troops fighting in Ukraine, declaring that they "face an aggressive force that is armed and sup-



Su-25 jets fly over Red Square leaving trails of smoke in the colors of the Russian flag during the Victory Day parade in Moscow, Saturday AP

ported by the entire bloc of NATO," and are fighting for a "just cause."

"Victory has always been and will be ours," Putin said, as columns of troops lined up on Red Square. "The key to success is our moral strength, courage and valour, our unity and ability to endure anything and overcome any challenge."

But in a notable shift this year, the parade took place without tanks, missiles and other heavy equipment, aside from a traditional flyover of combat jets.

Officials explained the sud-

den change of format by the "current operational situation" and said that additional security measures have been taken in response to the threat of Ukrainian attacks. State television commentators said that the heavy weaponry was more needed on the battlefield in Ukraine.

For the first time, Saturday's parade featured troops from North Korea, a tribute to Pyongyang that sent its soldiers to fight alongside Moscow forces to repel a Ukrainian incursion into Russia's Kursk region.

Marco Rubio defends US sanctions on Cuba, targeting military-run GAESA

HAVANA: US Secretary of State Marco Rubio defended the Trump administration's decision to slap new sanctions on Cuba, the largest of which is against GAESA, or Grupo de Administración Empresarial S.A., a business conglomerate operated by the Cuban Revolutionary Armed Forces.

In addition to GAESA and its leader, the sanctions announced Thursday included Moa Nickel, a Cuban joint venture with Canada's Sheritt International, which immediately announced it would withdraw from the business, ending a 32-year presence on the island.

The May 1 executive order and the new designations announced May 7 significantly expand the legal authority through which the US gov-

ernment can levy sanctions on third-country nationals and firms, explained Lee Schlenker, a research associate at the Quincy Institute's Global South program. "Not only are they subject to having their assets frozen but their US accounts as well as their travel to the US, that of their shareholders, investors or employees," said Schlenker. "This is bound to have an extremely significant impact of the presence of foreign companies" in Cuba.

Economist Pavel Vidal, a Cuba expert at Pontificia Universidad Javeriana, said that the measures are "very concerning" for an economy already "practically paralyzed." The US has blocked fuel shipments to Cuba since January, further escalating the island's yearslong economic crisis.

Trump says Russia and Ukraine have agreed to his request for 3-day ceasefire & prisoner swap

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump has said that the leaders of Russia and Ukraine have agreed to his request for a three-day ceasefire and an exchange of prisoners, adding that such a halt to hostilities could be the "beginning of the end" of the long war between them.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and Yuri Ushakov, Russian President Vladimir Putin's foreign affairs adviser, both confirmed the agreement.

"I asked and, President Putin agreed. President Zelenskyy agreed -- both readily," Trump said on Friday as he departed the White House to attend a dinner at his Virginia golf club. "And we have a little period of time where they're not going to be killing people. That's very good."

Trump earlier Friday had announced on social media that

the ceasefire would run Saturday through Monday. Saturday is Victory Day in Russia, a holiday that commemorates the victory over Nazi Germany in World War II.

"I am pleased to announce that there will be a THREE DAY CEASEFIRE (May 9th, 10th, and 11th) in the War between Russia and Ukraine," Trump wrote. "The Celebration in Russia is for Victory Day but, likewise, in Ukraine, because they were also a big part and factor of World War II."

The Republican president said the ceasefire includes a suspension of all kinetic activity and the exchange of 1,000 prisoners by each country.

Russia had announced a ceasefire for Friday and Saturday, but it quickly unravelled, with both sides blaming the other for the continued fighting, just as they had when Ukraine's

own unilateral ceasefire had swiftly collapsed earlier in the week.

Trump said he made his request for the ceasefire "directly" to the two presidents. "Hopefully, it is the beginning of the end of a very long, deadly, and hard fought War," he said. Trump added that talks continue over ending the war that began in February 2022 "and we are getting closer and closer every day." Trump has gone back and forth over whether the war will end, at times expressing optimism and at other times saying Russia and Ukraine should be left to fight it out to the bitter end.

Zelenskyy said Ukraine's decision on how to engage with those discussions was shaped in part by the prospect of freeing its prisoners. Ukraine has made the return of prisoners of war a central demand throughout

the conflict.

"Red Square matters less to us than the lives of Ukrainian prisoners of war who can be brought home," Zelenskyy wrote on Telegram. Red Square is where Russia holds its traditional military parade to celebrate Victory Day, one of the biggest holidays of the year.

After releasing his statement, Zelenskyy issued a formal presidential decree "authorising" Russia to hold the parade, declaring Red Square off-limits for Ukrainian strikes for the duration of the event. The framing of the decree appeared designed to underscore Kyiv's claim that it holds effective targeting reach over the Russian capital, while publicly tying Ukrainian restraint to the ceasefire terms. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov later shrugged off Zelenskyy's decree as a "silly joke".

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Shamsher Khan S/o Mohd. Yasin R/o H. No. C-4/598, Wood Market, Maharaja Ranjit Singh Road, LNJP Colony, Darya Ganj, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CC No. 15326/18, U/s 138 NI Act, PS Rajinder Nagar, (Central Distt.), New Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Shamsher Khan** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Shamsher Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Shamsher Khan** of case **CC No. 15326/18, U/s 138 NI Act, PS Rajinder Nagar, (Central Distt.), New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **12.06.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Arvind Tomar
Ld. Justice Magistrate First Class-07
Court No. 507
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/4887/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shahnawaj @ Sannu, S/o: Sayeed Ahmed, R/o: H.No-1058, Gali No-10, Jafrabad, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 124/2017, U/s: 324/509/34 IPC, P.S. Jafrabad, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Shahnawaj @ Sannu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Shahnawaj @ Sannu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shahnawaj @ Sannu of P.S. Jafrabad, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Anushtha Srivastava
Ld. JMFC-05, Room No. 07, 2nd Floor,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/5909/NE/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. CC-6/E-Auction/Commercial Publicity/2025 Dated: 8.05.2026

E-Auction Notice for Information

The Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, North Central Railway, has informally invited bids for the following e-auctions.

Parcel (Leasing)						
S. N.	Compartment	Train No.	CC (into nes)	From-To	Frequency (In a week)	E-Auction catalogue No.
1	FSLR-1	22443	3.9	CNB-BDTS	01 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-01
2	FSLR-RSLR	04125	3.9	SFG-BDTS	01 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-01
3	FSLR-1	22442	4.0	CNB-CKDT	07 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-02
4	RSLR-1	12275	3.9	PRYJ-NDLS	04 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-02
5	FSLR-1	12944	3.9	CNB-BL	01 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-01
6	FSLR-1	14117	3.9	PRYJ-BNW	07 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-01
7	VP	12451/52	14	PRYJ-NDLS	07 days	PRYJ-PRCL-26-03

Parking	Details of the auction	E-auction catalog No.	E-auction date & Time
1	Available Two wheeler, Three wheeler & Four wheeler Parking Stand Contract at Prayagraj Railway Station (City Side) for 07 Months.	PRKING-PRYJ-JMX	12.05.2026 at 10:00
2	Available Two wheeler, Three wheeler & Four wheeler Parking Stand Contract at Firozabad Railway Station for 03 Years.	PRKIG-FZD-MX-26	15.05.2026 at 11:30
3	Available Two wheeler, Three wheeler & Four wheeler Parking Stand Contract at Mirzapur Railway Station (2nd Entry) & Naini Railway Station for 03 Years.	PRKING-MZP-NNY	20.05.2026 at 11:00
4	Available Two wheeler, Three wheeler & Four wheeler Parking Stand Contract at Vindhyachal Railway Station & Mainpuri Railway Station for 03 Years.	PRKIG-MNQ-BDL	23.05.2026 at 11:00

Important note: Interested bidders may please visit official website for e-auctioning i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for further details and participating in e-Auction. 1045/26 (ADM)

North central railways @CPRONCR

TENERIFE (SPAIN): The head of the World Health Organisation arrived in Spain on Saturday to oversee the evacuation of more than 140 passengers and crew from a hantavirus-stricken cruise ship headed to the Canary Islands.

WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said he would be heading to the Spanish island of Tenerife off the coast of West Africa, along with senior Spanish government officials, "to oversee safe disembarkation of the passengers, crew members and health experts." The Dutch-flagged ship, the MV Hondius, is expected to arrive in Tenerife in the early hours

of Sunday. Tedros said that at this point, nobody on board the Hondius was showing symptoms of the virus.

"WHO continues to actively monitor the situation, coordinate support and next steps and will keep Member States and the public updated accordingly. So far, the risk for the population of Canary Islands and globally remains low," he posted on X.

Spain's Health Minister Monica Garcia said on Friday she would be heading to Tenerife with Tedros and Interior Fernando Grande-Marlaska to coordinate the disembarkation.

Three people have died since the outbreak, and five passengers who left the ship are

HIGHLIGHTS

» WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said he would be heading to the Spanish island of Tenerife off the coast of West Africa

» The head of Spain's emergency services, Virginia Barcones, has said passengers will be taken to a "completely isolated, cordoned-off area"

infected with hantavirus. Both the US and the UK have agreed to send planes to evacuate their citizens from the cruise ship.

The head of Spain's emergency services, Virginia Barcones, has said passengers will be taken to a "completely isolated, cordoned-off area" once they disembark. Hantavirus is usually spread by the inhalation

of contaminated rodent droppings and isn't easily transmitted between people. But the Andes virus detected in the cruise ship outbreak may be able to spread between people in rare cases. Symptoms usually show between one and eight weeks after exposure.

According to a letter sent by the Dutch foreign and health

ministers to parliament late Friday, Spain has activated the EU civil protection mechanism for a medical evacuation plane equipped for high-consequence infectious disease to be on standby. In case anyone falls ill, the medics on board the ship will inform the Spanish authorities, and the evacuation plane will be sent to Tenerife so that the sick person can be quickly transported by air to the European mainland.

The Dutch government will work with Spanish authorities and the ship company to arrange repatriation of Dutch passengers and crew as soon as possible after arrival in Tenerife, subject to medical conditions

and advice from the European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control, the letter said.

Those without symptoms will go into home quarantine for six weeks and be monitored by local health services.

As the ship is Dutch-flagged, the Netherlands may also temporarily accommodate people of other nationalities and monitor them in quarantine.

Health authorities across four continents were tracking down and monitoring more than two dozen passengers who disembarked before the deadly outbreak was detected. They were also scrambling to trace others who may have come into contact with them.

Four-midable Titans

Rashid and Gill to the fore to fashion GT's fourth straight win

JAIPUR: Leg-spinner Rashid Khan returned to his magical best with a four-wicket haul after his skipper Shubman Gill struck a sublime 84 as Gujarat Titans outclassed Rajasthan Royals by 77 runs to move a step closer to the IPL playoffs, here on Saturday.

Gill and Sai Sudharsan (55) stitched a commanding 118-run opening stand as Gujarat Titans piled up their season-best 229 for 4 after Rajasthan Royals opted to bowl on a batting-friendly deck.

In reply, Rajasthan began in explosive fashion through teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who smashed 36 off just 16 balls with the help of three fours and three sixes, while Dhruv Jurel kept up the momentum with a rapid 24 off 10 deliveries (1x4, 3x6).

At 62/2 in five overs, Rajasthan looked firmly in the chase before Gujarat's bowlers turned the game around to bowl the home side out for 152 in 16.3 overs. The victory was Gujarat Titans' fourth on the trot as they joined table-toppers Sunrisers Hyderabad on 14 points and tightened their grip on a playoff spot.

The pace duo of Kagiso Rabada (2/33 from 3 overs) and Mohammed Siraj (1/55) struck early blows in the powerplay



Rashid Khan returned with impressive figures of 4/33

before Rashid took complete control through the middle overs with a match-winning spell of 4/33.

Bowling between the

14th and 15th overs, Rashid exploited the slight turn on offer brilliantly and broke the backbone of Rajasthan's chase. He removed Jurel and Don-

ovan Ferreira in the space of three balls. He first knocked back Jurel's off stump with a teasing length delivery before rattling Ferreira with a sharp leg-break that drifted in and turned away. He later trapped Ravindra Jadeja lbw and finished with four wickets, including three bowled dismissals, as Rajasthan kept losing wickets at regular intervals and handed the biggest win to GT.

Jason Holder wrapped up the tail returning with figures of 3/12 in his 2.3 overs.

Sooryavanshi gave Rajasthan a flying start by smashing the very first ball of the innings for six. He then took on Rabada with back-to-back sixes as the Royals raced to 26 without loss in two overs.

Siraj too came under attack, conceding three boundaries in four balls to the fearless youngster. But the India pacer eventually had the last laugh with a well-directed short ball that forced a mistimed pull, ending Sooryavanshi's entertaining cameo. Rabada then struck another big blow in the following over, dismissing Yashasvi Jaiswal, who led RR on Saturday after regular captain Riyan Parag pulled his hamstring in the previous match, with a 152kph bouncer that was mis-

cued to extra cover. AGENCIES

RCB look to break losing streak vs MI

RAIPUR: Royal Challengers Bengaluru will want their batting group to rebuild its muscle to snap a two-match losing streak, and put their IPL campaign back on track when they face Mumbai Indians here on Sunday.

The Royal Challengers were off to an early season flier, winning four out of their first matches and the play-offs entry appeared a mere formality.

But now the situation has changed. The title holders have lost three of their last five matches to slip into a little mid-tournament crisis.

RCB, who is currently third on the table with 12 points from 10 matches, are still in a prime position to enter the knockout stage.

But the Bengaluru outfit will certainly be aware that they have lost a bit of steam towards the business end of the tournament.

The RCB are tied with Rajasthan Royals and Gujarat Titans on 12 points, and either RR or GT will go ahead when after their Saturday's match at Jaipur, pushing the Bengalureans down to fourth.

That points table scenario in itself is slightly worrying, but apart from that external factor, the RCB will need the batting group regaining its range. On a tad tacky Ahmedabad pitch against the Titans, the RCB batters failed to go beyond 155 and even the 9-run DLS margin defeat against Lucknow Super Giants was not as close as the margin suggests.

The RCB required 19 runs in the final over to cross the line, but could not come close to that. AGENCIES

DP World PGTI tees off 2026 season with Rs 14-cr boost

NEW DELHI: The DP World Professional Golf Tour of India (DP World PGTI) has launched its 2026 season on a strong note, unveiling a packed calendar of 12 tournaments with a combined prize purse of Rs 14 crore. The season reflects a significant rise in scale, prize money and innovation, while also expanding international participation and strengthening the pathway for emerging Indian golfers.

The first half of the season features three events offering prize purses of Rs 1.5 crore each and another three carrying Rs 1 crore purses. In addition, two marquee tournaments boast prize money of US\$300,000 (approximately Rs 2.76 crore), placing them among the richest events on the domestic circuit. In a major development for Indian golf, DP World has come on board as the Title and Umbrella Partner of the tour. AGENCIES

Jadhav wins maiden World Cup medal with bronze in Shanghai

SHANGHAI: Reigning World University Games champion Sahil Jadhav clinched his maiden Archery World Cup medal in only his second appearance on the global circuit, winning a bronze in the compound men's event of the Stage 2 here on Saturday.

The 25-year-old Maharashtra archer defeated Denmark veteran player-cum-coach Martin Damsbo 147-144 in the bronze medal playoff to secure India's first medal of the ongoing tournament.

It also marked India's final medal in the compound section after none of his fellow mates reached the medal rounds. India, traditionally a powerhouse in compound team events, had endured a disappointing campaign as all their teams bowed out early.

India will now look to add two more medals on the concluding day on Sunday in the recurve section.

The women's team will compete for gold, while Simranjeet Kaur will begin her



Sahil Jadhav beat Martin Damsbo of Denmark 147-144

It also marked India's final medal in the compound section after none of reached the medal rounds

campaign from the semifinals, needing one win to secure her maiden World Cup medal.

Jadhav was trailing by one point after the opening end

as the 40-year-old Damsbo started with three perfect 10s.

But the Indian responded strongly in the second end, shooting a perfect 30 while the Dane managed 27, helping Jadhav move ahead 59-57 overall.

From there, Jadhav stayed firmly in control, dropping just two points from his final nine arrows to seal a memorable three-point victory. Jadhav, who had made his World Cup debut last month in Puebla, enjoyed a breakthrough campaign in Shanghai. AGENCIES

Barcelona look to wrap up title as they host Real

BARCELONA: It would be a day to remember at Camp Nou if Barcelona can beat Real Madrid and clinch the Spanish league in one swoop.

Barcelona host Madrid on Sunday savoring the opportunity to celebrate a second straight La Liga crown with a victory or even a draw when it plays its fiercest rivals.

Hansi Flick's team leads Madrid by 11 points with four rounds left, so it can afford the slip, while Madrid is mostly playing for pride and to avoid the humiliation of watching Barcelona celebrate at its expense.

Only a Madrid victory at Barcelona's stadium can avoid the title going to the host.

"We're fully switched on and we want the win because it would be the best way to clinch the league title," Barcelona defender Jules Koundé said.

The clasico will be the first in over three years at Camp Nou, which was closed for refurbishment until midway through this season.

Players to watch

The clasico could be Robert Lewandowski's last in a Barcelona shirt, so all eyes will be on his performance. The 37-year-old Poland striker has lost his first-choice status for Flick, and his contract is expiring this summer.

Raphinha could see some playing time after the forward returned to the team's squad in the last round after having missed several games with an injury. It is still likely that he will start on the bench, with Marcus Rashford and Fermin López poised to make the starting frontline along with

Barca seek final push



This could be Robert Lewandowski's last clasico

Boos as Liverpool draw Chelsea

MANCHESTER: Liverpool fans jeered as the defending Premier League champion dropped more points on Saturday.

A 1-1 draw with Chelsea at Anfield saw Liverpool move a step closer to guaranteed Champions League qualification — fourth in the table with two rounds left — but another

unconvincing performance sparked a frustrated reaction from the crowd.

There were boos at the final whistle to mark growing unrest from Liverpool supporters in a season that has seen the team tamely surrender the title despite spending around \$570 million in the transfer market. AGENCIES

Lewandowski or Ferran Torres.

Madrid's hopes of delaying Barcelona's title — and keeping alive its own fragile title bid — will likely rest on Vinicius Junior. The Brazil forward is finishing the campaign in top form.

He has four goals in his last

three league games and has 15 goals in the competition.

The mood of Madrid's squad as a whole will be scrutinized after arguments and even scuffles by players during practice this week as the team faces a second straight season without a major trophy. AGENCIES

INELIGIBLE TO COMPETE TILL JUNE 26

No comeback: WFI pins Vinesh with explosive showcase notice

S KANNAN

NEW DELHI: The Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) has issued a strongly worded 15-page showcause notice to star wrestler and Haryana MLA Vinesh Phogat following her recent social media video in which she accused the federation, the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, and the Indian Olympic Association of obstructing her return to competitive wrestling.

The notice, served on Saturday, accuses Phogat of "indiscipline," damaging the image of Indian wrestling, and violating anti-doping regulations.

Phogat, who currently serves as an MLA from Julana in Haryana, had announced her retirement after the heart-break of the 2024 Paris Olympics, where she was disqualified ahead of the gold medal bout for being 100 gm overweight in the 50kg category. Her dramatic exit from the Games triggered nationwide debate and marked the beginning of her political journey. After giving birth to a son in July 2025, Phogat began preparing for a return to the mat toward the end of the year. However, her comeback bid has now run into controversy.

WFI's sharp criticism



The notice accuses Phogat of "indiscipline" and damaging the image of Indian wrestling

In the showcause notice, the WFI held Phogat directly responsible for what it described as a major embarrassment for Indian wrestling at the Paris Olympics.

"Your failure to manage your own weight in the highest international competition, after voluntarily opting to drop down to the 50kg category from your usual higher weight category, resulted in: (a) the loss of an assured Olympic medal for India; (b) the silver medal

being awarded to another nation; (c) widespread negative media coverage; and (d) lasting damage to the reputation of Indian wrestling and the WFI," the notice stated.

The federation has also accused Phogat of violating anti-doping protocols related to "whereabouts failure" and non-compliance with Registered Testing Pool (RTP) obligations.

According to the WFI, Phogat was re-entered into the testing pool after deciding to resume competitive wrestling but allegedly failed to make herself available for mandatory urine sample collection during the required six-month period following her return.

Additionally, the federation cited an alleged violation of United World Wrestling (UWW) competition rules during the March 2024 Olympic trials, claiming that Phogat competed in two weight categories — something not permitted under the regulations.

As a consequence, Phogat has been barred from participating in the National Open Ranking Tournament scheduled to be held in Gonda, Uttar Pradesh, from May 10 to 12. The tournament was expected to play a key role in selection pathways for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This notification is to inform all the members of "The bhallabgarh co-operative marketing society that societie's board of directors election has been decided to be on 21-06-2026 in society office. Election program has been decided by assistant registrar co-oprative society faridabad and election officer as in joint as below .Nominations will be accepted by 22th May 2026, 2 PM. List of candidates will be released by 3 PM who filed nominations and checking of nomination on 25th of May 2026 by 2 PM. while 29th May 2026 will be the last date to withdraw of nominations. Symbols will be distributed to the candidates on 29th May 2026 3PM. In evening by 4PM, final list of candidates with symbols will be released. All activities related election will be held at asstt. Registrar co-oprative societie's faridabad office.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender Notice for supply of materials "Participation in through" web portal of IREPS-www.ireps.gov.in offers are invited for supply of following materials:- (1) Tender No.:36256147 Brief Description: Bombardier make Traction Motor with pinion for MRVC phase-2 Bombardier rakes Type-MIT, RAC TM 1800 S (MJC280-1), Bombardier ID No. 3EJD 000001-1504 Quantity:04 Nos Closing on:03.06.2026 The Closing time for all tenders is at 14:00 HRS. Eligible participants are required to submit their offer only through e-procurement web portal of IREPS-www.ireps.gov.in before the closing date and time. Other details regarding Consigned and detailed description of stores are available in tender documents in the tender notice on above portal. Sr. DMM/ECR/DDU PR/0195/DDU/Material/T/26-27/28

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: 2020262027 Dated: 07.05.2026

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE
Sr. DEN/Co./North Central Railway, Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites online open tenders (E-tender, Two Packet System) as detailed below:-

E-Tender Notice No.	Approx Cost (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (In Rs.)
2020262027-69	Rs. 14,57,39,437.67	Rs. 29,14,800.00

Name of Work: Construction of 10-Units Type-V quarters in Prayagraj under North Central Railway, Prayagraj division.

Completion Period: 12 Months Nature of work: Construction of Building.

Date & Time of Closing of tender: 29.05.2026 at 12:00 PM

Note: 1. For full details and submission of tenders, please see the Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. 2. Tender offer shall be made on line through Two Packet System i.e. (i) Technical Bid (ii) Financial Bid. 1037/26 (ADM)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Open Tender No.- JHS-RCNK-M-SPR-26-27-08

E-Tender Notice
E-tenders are invited by the Chief Workshop Manager, Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana, on behalf of the President of India, from experienced and interested contractors for the work mentioned below:-

Name of Work: Maintenance/Overhauling of Rolling Stock Springs at RCNK Jhansi.

Cost of work : Rs. 11,34,89,920.50/- (Including 18% GST)

Earnest Money Deposit/Bid Security : Rs. 22,69,800.00/-

Time of completion : Sixty Months

Online Tender Closing Date and Time : 02.06.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.

Detailed information about tender and tender format is available at website www.ireps.gov.in 1022/26 (AS)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. 1920262027 Date: 07.05.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice
Sr. DEN/Co./North Central Railway, Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites online open tenders (E-tender) as detailed below:-

E-Tender Notice No.: 1920262027-68

Name of work: Construction of holiday homes at Gau Ghat in Prayagraj under North Central Railway, Prayagraj division.

Approx Cost : ₹ 36180560.03 Earnest Money: ₹ 723600.00

Completion Period: 08 Months Nature of work: Construction of Building

Date & Time of Closing of tender: 29.05.2026 at 12.00 PM

Note: For full details and submission of tenders, please see the Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. 1036/26 FA

North central railways @ CPONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No. : DRMC/AGRA/PARKING/E-AUCTION/2026 Dated : 07.05.2026

E-AUCTION NOTICE
On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category : Parking Auction Catalogue No. : PARKING-AGRA-01

Asset Details : Idgah Jn. Railway Station, IDH Station PF-1, Circulating Area-Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers Parking.

E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 22.05.2026 Time : 12:15

E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 22.05.2026 Time : 12:45

Note : Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1030/26 (AS)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPONCR

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS KATHUA
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammujkpolice.gov.in

LOOK OUT NOTICE
SHO P/S Pacca Danga, Jammu has intimated that on 04.05.2026 an information received at P/S Pacca Danga through PCR that one person namely Sumit was admitted at GMCH Jammu, during treatment died. To ascertain the actual cause of death, Inquest proceedings U/S 194 BNSS, was initiated at P/S Pacca Danga vide DDR No. 33 dated 04.05.2026 and enquiry thereof started. During Probe, E/O shifted dead body to mortuary room of GMCH, Jammu for identification.

For identification of said dead body wide publicity is required to be published on daily newspapers for identification / Public in general, having any clue related to the dead body. If any missing report is lodged, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact/ Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :
Name : Sumit
Age : 40 years (Approx.)
Complexion : Wheatish
Height : 5'6"
Dress : T-Shirt, Pant

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-
DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
PCR Jammu : 0191-2542000
SP City North : 0191-2547038
SDO City North : 0191-2566621
Landline of P/S Pacca Danga : 0191-2548610
DIP/J-1794/26

Sd/-Sr. Superintendent of Police, Jammu.

ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

प्लॉट सं. 01, नालेज चार्क-IV, ग्रेटर नौएडा, गौतमबुद्ध नगर, उत्तर प्रदेश-201308
वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in ई-मेल: authority@gnida.in

पत्रांक: वरि0प्र0 / (ई-निविदा सेल) / (वर्क सर्किल-8) / 2026 / 926(A) दिनांक: 08/05/2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

महाप्रबन्धक (अभियन्त्रण) ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नौएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-वरि0प्र0 / (वर्क सर्किल-8) / 2026 / 926 दिनांक 08/05/2026 के माध्यम से उल्लेखित क्रम संख्या-01 से 04 तक के कार्य की ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नौएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट : www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल tenders.up.nic.in पर उपलब्ध हैं। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम/ वर्क सर्किल	अनुमानित लागत
निर्माण का कार्य		
1.	ग्रेटर नौएडा के ग्राम खानपुर, बल्ला की मढ़ैया एवं गिश्चपुर में कम्पोजिट विद्यालय में क्लास रूम, बरामदे का निर्माण एवं मरम्मत का कार्य। (वर्क सर्किल-8)	रु. 143.29 लाख
2.	ग्रेटर नौएडा के ग्राम सलेमपुर गुर्जर में कम्पोजिट विद्यालय में बाजण्डी वॉल, क्लास रूम और शौचालय का निर्माण और मरम्मत कार्य। (वर्क सर्किल-8)	रु. 49.76 लाख
3.	ग्रेटर नौएडा के ग्राम घंघोला और शिरसा में क्लास रूम, बरामदा और शौचालय का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्किल-8)	रु. 80.51 लाख
4.	ग्रेटर नौएडा के ग्राम बिरौडा में कम्पोजिट स्कूल में क्लास रूम, बरामदा और इण्टरलॉकिंग टाईल्स का निर्माण व मरम्मत कार्य। (वर्क सर्किल-8)	रु. 30.84 लाख

क्रम सं.-01, से 04 तक के कार्यों को दिनांक-12.05.2026 से 21.05.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 25.05.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी।
वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (वर्क सर्किल-8)

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झारखण्ड सरकार

ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग
कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय
कम्पाईण्ड बिल्डिंग, प्रथम तल्ला, एलबीसी रोड, धनबाद

ई- निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

ई-निविदा संख्या:- 03/RWD/DHANBAD/26-27 दिनांक :- 08.05.2026

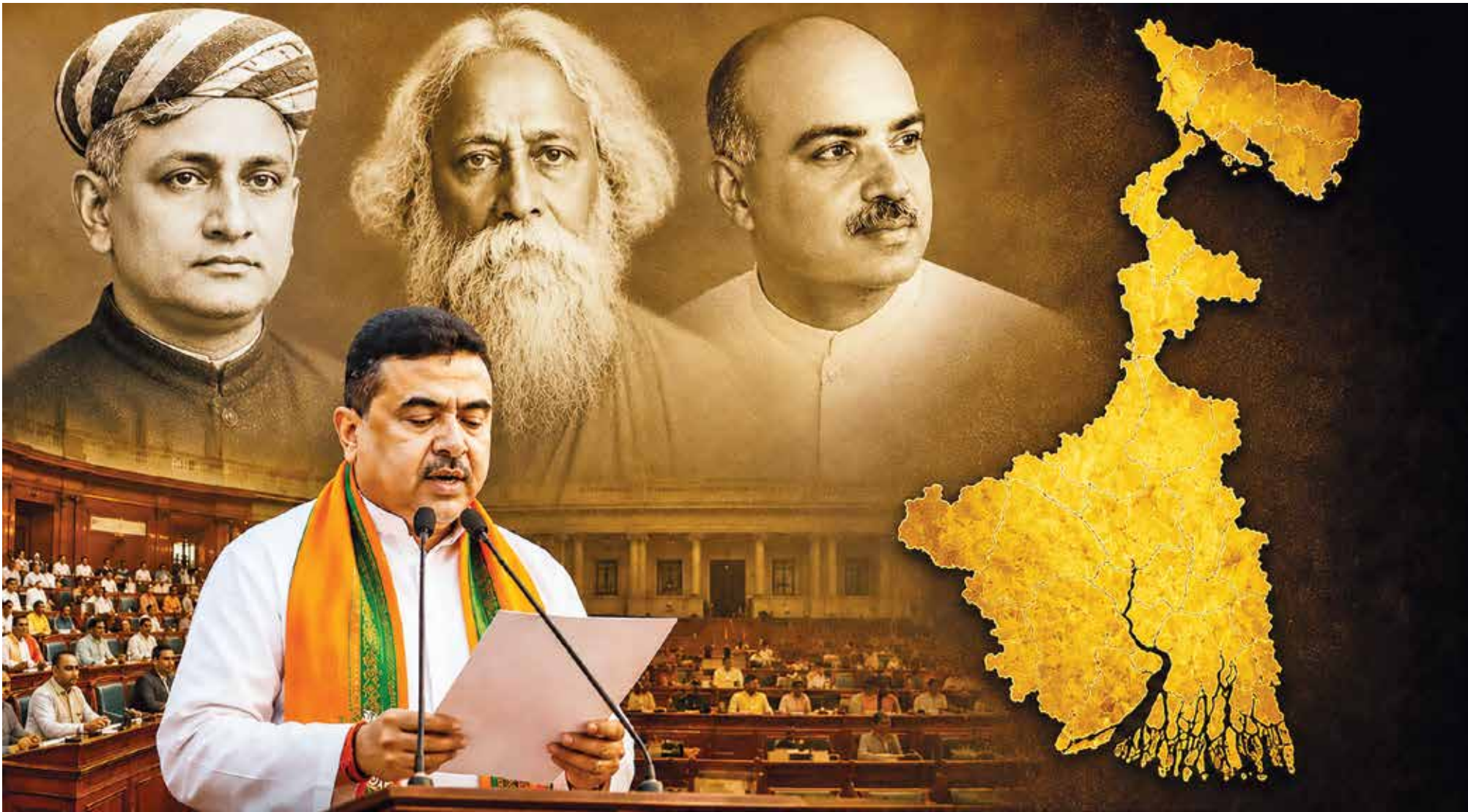
कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, धनबाद द्वारा निम्न विवरण के अनुसार e-procurement पद्धति से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र० सं०	आईडेंटि फिकेशन संख्या / वेंकेज संख्या	प्रखण्ड	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (लाख में)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	टेंडरर कोट संख्या
1	RWD/DHN/1/2/24-25	तोपचांची	साहू बहियार स्वास्थ्य केन्द्र से नकटीडीह (विशुनपुर) माया चितरपुर, खानुडीह तक पथ निर्माण कार्य (लम्बाई 5.365 कि०मी०)	750.335	सात करोड़ पचास लाख तैसी हजार पाँच सौ	18 माह द्वितीय

2. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि:- 13.05.2026
3. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय:- 03.06.2026 अपराह्न 5.00 बजे तक।
4. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय:- 05.06.2026 अपराह्न 3.30 बजे तक।
5. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता:- कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, धनबाद, पिन-826001
6. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं०- 0326-36544757
विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट jharkhandtenders.gov.in में देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, धनबाद

PR 379419 Rural Work Department(26-27),D



Bengal Mandate & the Rise of Hindutva

FROM BANKIM CHANDRA TO SHYAMA PRASAD MUKHERJEE, THE ROOTS OF HINDUTVA POLITICS IN BENGAL RUN FAR DEEPER THAN CONTEMPORARY ELECTORAL RHETORIC SUGGESTS

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

Bengali ‘gentlefolk’ (Bhadrolak) awaited over 134 years, till May 4, 2026, for a tryst with ‘Hindutva’ with the victory of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) — the Hindu nationalist party — in the last Assembly election. While Hindutva — a term coined by Bengali author and scholar Chandranath Basu in his 1892 book *Hindutva: Hindur Prakrita Itihas* to represent the essence of Sanatana Dharma and to assert the superiority of Hindu traditions over Western culture — was later popularised and given a specifically political, cultural, and nationalistic definition by Vinayak Damodar Savarkar in his 1923 pamphlet *Hindutva: Who is a Hindu?* BJP’s victory ended 15 years of All India Trinamool Congress (TMC) rule led by Mamata Banerjee. Suwendu Adhikari, a former TMC minister, took oath as the first BJP Chief Minister of West Bengal on Saturday (May 9, 2026). Incidentally, May 9 coincided with the 165th birth anniversary of Rabindranath Tagore, the writer of the national anthems of India and Bangladesh, who consistently criticised the concept of the Nation-State and nationalism. Tagore wrote that the narrowness generated by nationalism obstructs man’s natural freedom and spiritual development, and considered nationalism war-mongering and anti-social because the uncontrolled use of state power in its name gave birth to many crimes. Political analysts have identified three major factors that have contributed to the contemporary resurgence of Hindutva politics in West Bengal:

- a historic revival and consolidation of Hindu political consciousness led by Hindutva politics;
- the myth of radical and progressive Bengali consciousness;
- the failure of the Left to dismantle the Brahminical social order.

Historical roots of Hindutva politics in Bengal

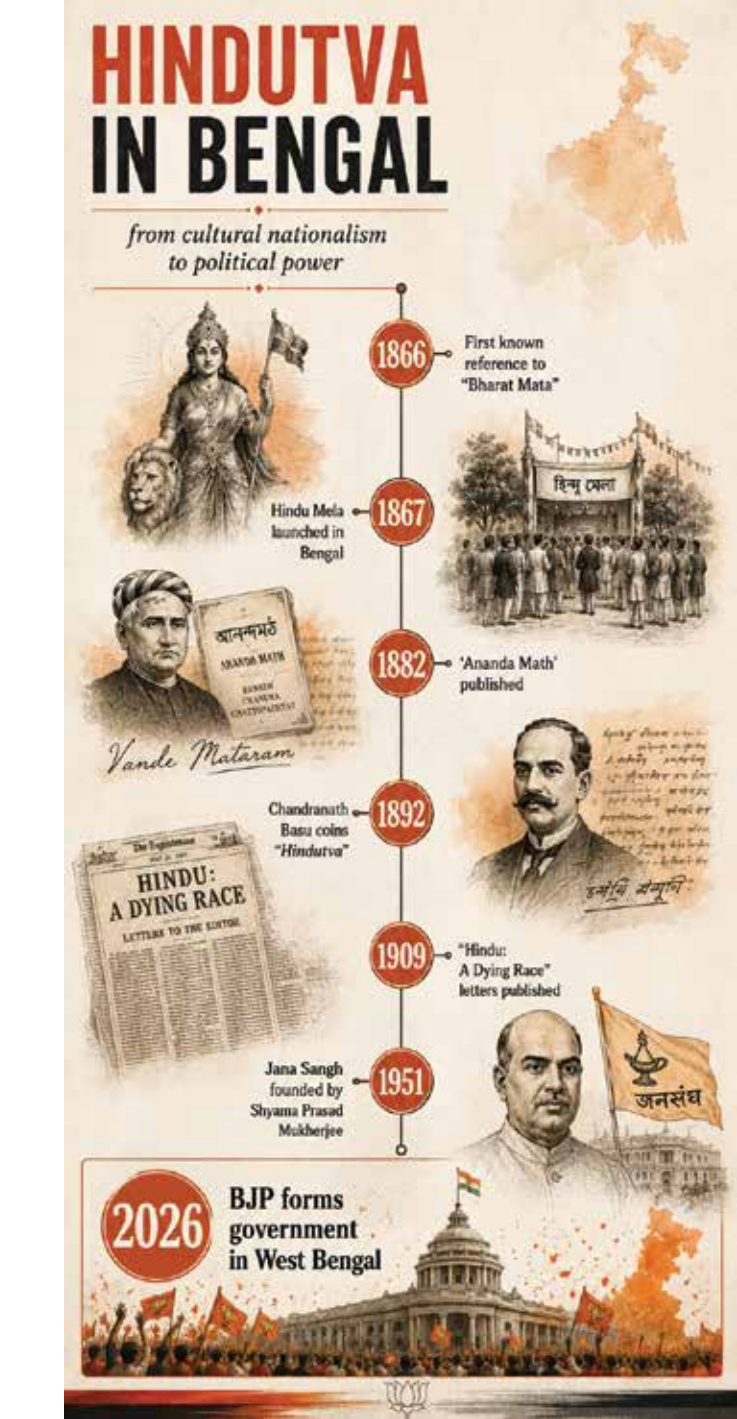
Historians trace that, in addition to the very word Hindutva, the concepts of Bharat Mata and the Bande Mataram slogan were products of Bengal. Hindu revivalism emerged in Bengal in the second half of the 19th century as a reaction to the influence of Western education and culture on Hindu society during the first half of that century. It is claimed that

the visualisation and depiction of India as a ‘mother’ started gaining popularity during the late 1860s. The first published reference to the coinage ‘Bharat Mata’ has been traced to a satirical Bengali book, *Unabingsho Puran (The Nineteenth Purana)*, published in 1866 under the pseudonym of Krishnadwaipayana Vedavyasa. Bhudeb Mukhopadhyay, a scholar and writer, is generally regarded as its anonymous author. He was part of Bengal’s Hindu revivalism. Discussing Mukhopadhyay and his times, linguist Suniti Kumar Chatterjee wrote that the atmosphere in the colleges and high schools during 1840–1870 was not healthy for the Bengali mind and culture, and that an ‘inferiority complex’ gripped the Bengali psyche — by Bengali, he meant Bengali Hindus — after exposure to Western education, knowledge, and culture.

In 1867, Debendranath Tagore, along with poet-playwright-editor Nabagopal Mitra and essayist Rajnarayan Basu, took the lead in organising the Hindu Mela, which was alternatively called *jatityo mela* (national fair). The fair was inaugurated with a patriotic song composed by Rabindranath’s elder brother, Dwijendranath, addressing Bharat, the mother: ‘Malina Mukhochandra, Maa Bharat Tomari’ (‘You look pale, Mother India’). Bengali Bhadrakolok — a complicated concept that can be summarily understood as representative of the upper-caste Bengalis consisting primarily of Brahmins, Baidyas, and Kayasthas, and the literati of Bengal in general — flocked in large numbers to the Hindu Mela. Towards the end of the 1870s, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay penned the hymn *Bande Mataram*. The hymn became part of his landmark and controversial literary work *Ananda Math*, published in 1882.

Hindu revivalism took a different shape at the beginning of the twentieth century with the numerical increase of Muslims and the Muslim elites’ efforts to secure rights and benefits for the community. In June 1909, a series of letters titled ‘Hindu: A Dying Race’, written by Lt Col. U.N. Mukerji, an Indian Medical Service officer, appeared in Bengalee, a Kolkata-based English-language newspaper owned and edited by veteran Congress leader Surendranath Banerjee. Historians identified these letters, later compiled into a pamphlet and also published as a book, as the foundational basis of the notion that Hindus were in danger and needed to wake up and act. ‘The Hindus are in danger’ has been made a major election issue by the BJP to polarise Hindu votes against Muslims.

Prafulla Chandra Ray published *A History of Hindu Chemistry* in two volumes in 1902 and 1909, claiming that the ancient wisdom of Hindus was far in advance of the rest of the world. In the preface to the second volume, P.C. Ray wrote: ‘The Hindu nation with its glorious past and vast latent potentialities may



yet look forward to a still more glorious future, and, if the perusal of these pages will have the effect of stimulating my countrymen to strive for regaining their old position in the intellectual hierarchy of nations, I shall not have laboured in vain.’ P.C. Ray was instrumental in the establishment of Swadeshi industries. He founded Bengal Chemicals & Pharmaceuticals and was associated with the establishment of the now-defunct Calcutta Chemicals in 1916. The probable Finance Minister of West Bengal, Swapna Dasgupta, is the grandson of one of the founders of Calcutta Chemicals.

The formation of the Hindutva gov-

ernment in West Bengal also coincides with the 125th birth anniversary of Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, considered one of the architects of the division of Bengal in 1947 on religious lines. Mukherjee joined the Hindu Mahasabha in Bengal in 1939 and became its acting president that same year. He demanded the partition of Bengal in 1946 to prevent the inclusion of its Hindu-majority areas in a Muslim-dominated East Pakistan. In May 1947, he wrote to Lord Mountbatten stating that Bengal must be partitioned even if India was not. He also opposed the failed bid for a united but independent Bengal made in 1947

by Sarat Bose, the brother of Subhas Chandra Bose, and Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy, a Bengali Muslim politician. Following the Hindu Mahasabha’s official decision to boycott the Quit India movement and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh’s decision not to participate in it, Mukherjee wrote a letter dated July 26, 1942, to Sir John Herbert, Governor of Bengal, explaining how they should respond to the movement. Mukherjee founded the Bharatiya Jana Sangh on October 21, 1951, in Delhi and became its first president. In 1977, it merged with several other parties to form the Janata Party. In 1980, members of the erstwhile Jana Sangh quit the Janata Party after its defeat in the general election and formed the BJP, which is the direct political successor to the Jana Sangh. The Government of India is celebrating Dr Shyama Prasad Mukherjee’s 125th birth anniversary from July 6, 2025, to July 6, 2027.

Geopolitical importance of West Bengal

With rapid shifts in global politics — especially in the Middle East and East Asia — the Bay of Bengal region has emerged as a strategically important area for the United States. Four major elections have taken place during the last three months along its coast — Myanmar, Bangladesh, West Bengal, and Tamil Nadu. China has already established a strong presence in Myanmar and Bangladesh. The United States is desperately looking for a base in this region to counter China’s growing influence in South Asia. The congratulatory message sent by US President Donald Trump to Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi following BJP’s decisive victory in the recently concluded Assembly polls in West Bengal indicates the geostrategic importance of West Bengal to the US administration. Trump did not mention Tamil Nadu, where BJP lost. His excitement over BJP’s victory in a state election — an internal matter of India’s federal democracy — suggests long-term US interest in Bengal, which acts as a gateway to the entire Northeast through the narrow Siliguri Corridor, known as the Chicken’s Neck.

Bangladesh shares a 4,096-kilometre (2,545-mile) international border with five Indian states — West Bengal, Tripura, Meghalaya, Mizoram, and Assam. Among them, Mizoram also shares a border with Myanmar. BJP is the single largest ruling party in three border states — West Bengal, Assam, and Tripura. A day after BJP won a historic majority in the West Bengal Assembly elections, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman said on Tuesday (May 5) that Dhaka would take action if “push-in” incidents occurred following the change of government in the state. Reacting to this, India’s Ministry of External Affairs said on Thursday (May 7, 2026) that the

repatriation of Bangladeshi citizens illegally staying in India is a “core issue” in the Delhi-Dhaka relationship. Last week, the Bangladesh government summoned acting Indian High Commissioner Pawan Badhe to protest what it described as “anti-Bangladeshi remarks” made by Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. Political analyst Altaf Parvez has expressed concerns that the electoral victories of BJP in India’s border states — West Bengal, Assam, and Tripura — could create pressure on various issues along both sides of the Bangladesh-India border. Further deterioration in Indo-Bangladesh relations will adversely impact millions of people on both sides of the border who share a common ecosystem.

On May 6, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman arrived in Beijing for talks with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi to boost bilateral cooperation. It has been reported that during the meeting, both sides reaffirmed the Bangladesh-China comprehensive strategic cooperative partnership and expressed commitment to strengthening cooperation in trade, investment, connectivity, and development. During the meeting, Bangladesh formally sought China’s support for the Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project (TRCMRP), a move that could add fresh strain to relations between Dhaka and New Delhi amid growing Chinese influence in the region. Significantly, on May 6, twelve senior Bangladeshi officials began training in Pakistan. This marks the first structured programme for Bangladeshi bureaucrats in Pakistan since the early 1970s. The training, fully funded by Pakistan, focuses on comparative learning of administrative systems. This engagement follows increased interaction between the two nations since Sheikh Hasina’s ouster in August 2024.

After winning the February 2026 elections, the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) is back in power. BNP’s “Bangladesh First” manifesto promises ambitious infrastructure development, expansion of port capacity, and a target of generating 35,000 megawatts of electricity by 2030. Its nuclear power plant has become operational. BNP is now part of the China-Bangladesh-Pakistan axis. It may be recalled that Bangladesh’s late former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia and her party, the BNP, consistently adopted an anti-India policy. Things took a turn for the worse during her tenures as Bangladesh Prime Minister from 1991 to 1996 and from 2001 to 2006. Zia’s BNP is said to have sheltered leaders of militant groups in India’s Northeast.

Further deterioration in Indo-Bangladesh relations will provide an opportunity for deep states to directly interfere in the internal affairs of West Bengal and the Northeastern states. The recent comment by the US President on the Bengal election is a case in point.

WELLNESS

DANGEROUS
AUTHORITY OF
INFLUENCERS



India's influencer economy increasingly blurs content and clinical advice through fake diagnoses, wellness claims, and unchecked misinformation

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

followers to stop medication and instead offer paid healing programmes for conditions requiring clinical intervention, reframing serious psychiatric presentations as spiritual crises. A recent investigation found that over half of popular mental health content on social media contained inaccuracies or outright falsehoods, frequently promoting quick fixes and questionable products.

What should India do?

The Department of Consumer Affairs has mandated qualification disclosure, with penalties under consumer protection law. The Indian Medical Association has raised alarms. The Advertising Standards Council has issued guidelines. China's model is pre-emptive. Credentials before posting, not apologies after harm. Spain's 2024 Influencer Law requires creators with over one million followers to register and follow guidelines. India's model remains reactive: wait for the complaint, investigate, by which time the reel has twelve million views and the damage is permanent. If you repeat a lie enough times, it begins to sound like the truth, aka the illusory truth effect. Algorithms call it engagement.

THE "REAL" DOCTOR has 120 followers. The "REEL" doctor has 1.2 million

Way forward

The pathway requires three things working simultaneously. Platform accountability: Instagram, YouTube, and X must be held legally responsible for health content that causes demonstrable harm. Engagement metrics cannot be the only Authority standard. Credential visibility: Any health, fitness, nutrition, or mental health content must display qualifications prominently in the video itself, not buried in a bio. A fitness influencer is not a dietitian. A life coach is not a therapist. A spiritual healer is not a psychiatrist. The audience deserves to know the difference before acting on the advice. Clinical counter-presence: Doctors and evidence-based practitioners must occupy social media with the same energy the quacks do. The antidote to misinformation is not only regulation, but also credible, engaging clinical voices. This article too is one of them. Remember, a large following is not a medical degree. It is time India's regulatory system said so, loudly, legally, and with consequences.

Watt Happened to
Tesla in India

In just a year, Tesla's much-hyped India EV entry has run headlong into a brutal reality. Indian buyers are admiring the American dream, but refusing to buy it

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN



THE INDIAN MARKET DID NOT REJECT TESLA. IT SIMPLY ASKED A question. ELON MUSK CLEARLY NEVER EXPECTED: 'AT RS 60 LAKH, WHY THE HELL SHOULD WE CARE?'

For a decade, it was ballyhooed as the grandest of all arrivals. Tesla's India story was to resemble one of those Bollywood blockbusters whose trailer refuses to end. There were tweets, policy negotiations, whispers of factories, diplomatic overtures, endless speculation and a fanboy frenzy bordering on religious devotion. Every sighting of a camouflaged Tesla on Indian roads triggered social media hysteria. Every cryptic remark from Elon Musk was dissected like sacred scripture. Then, Tesla finally arrived. But this coming was anything but a bang, and more of a polite electronic hum. Last year's launch of the Model Y was supposed to redraw the nation's auto map. Instead, Tesla's cars have become rare sightings in Mumbai, Delhi and Gurugram; more conversation starters than market disruptors. Prices hovering around Rs 60 lakh and above shoved the brand into India's luxury niche, far removed from the mass-market revolution many had imagined it would be. India, as Tesla has discovered, is not California with cows.

PRICE & EV-SENSITIVE

This is a market where buyers calculate fuel efficiency at traffic lights, negotiate hard for accessories like diplomats and calculate resale values with actuarial precision. In a country where even affluent consumers demand 'value-for-money', Tesla's global aura alone was never going to be enough. Yes, the curiosity was immense. But the on-ground conversion, not so much. The problem is not that Indians dislike electric vehicles. Quite the opposite. The nation's EV market is growing at startling speed. Passenger EV sales surged in FY 2025-26, while overall electric mobility became increasingly mainstream. The problem for Tesla is that this EV boom has evolved differently from what the Elon Musk firm expected. The market is not being led by aspirational futurism, but by ruthless pragmatism. Consumers are asking

tough questions. How far will it go in Delhi traffic with the air-conditioning blasting in May and June? Where is the service network? How expensive is battery replacement? Can it survive monsoon flooding? Will spare parts arrive before retirement?

TAXES & COMPETITION

Tesla's imported pricing structure amplifies those concerns. Steep import duties have ensured that Tesla entered not as a mass disruptor, but as an expensive curiosity. Numbers show VinFast and BYD have been outperforming Tesla, helped by aggressive localisation and pricing strategies. And don't forget Tata Motors and Mahindra Auto; they haven't exactly rolled over in fear. Tata Motors spent years building India's EV ecosystem when few others bothered. Mahindra suddenly transformed itself into an aggressive EV challenger; the result is that Mahindra's electric SUVs have posted explosive growth, seeing the company rapidly expand its EV marketshare. There is also the Chinese shadow that looms over everything. Globally, Chinese EV makers have changed the economics of electric mobility. They manufacture faster, cheaper and often better. Indian consumers are aware that Chinese brands offer extraordinary technology at prices others struggle to match. Even online chatter among Indian buyers laments the gap between Chinese innovation and what reaches the showrooms. Tesla, once the hunter, is being hunted. Crowded showrooms What makes the India challenge excruciating for Tesla is that the market no longer lacks options. This is not 2018, when EVs meant a choice between compromise

and inconvenience. Today's market is like a political rally where everyone is shouting promises through louder microphones (and similar to politics, the promisers don't really care if the never deliver on the promise). VinFast from Vietnam is expanding boldly. JSW MG Motor India is gaining traction. Chery's team-ups and Chinese interest keep hovering in the background. Hyundai, Maruti Suzuki and others are stepping deeper into electrification. Unlike Tesla, these companies understand a brutal truth: India is a market that rewards adaptation, not arrogance. Consumers may like touchscreen technology and large displays, but they also like physical service centres nearby. They want cars that survive potholes capable of swallowing small democracies. They want affordability wrapped inside aspiration. Tesla's minimalist philosophy – stripped-down interiors, sparse buttons, software-heavy interaction – feels futuristic in Silicon Valley. In India, where luxury buyers often equate value with visible excess, the approach risks appearing oddly underwhelming. There is also the infrastructure problem. Tesla's Supercharger ecosystem helped build its dominance globally. In India, charging infrastructure remains fragmented and inconsistent outside urban clusters. The company's limited physical footprint further compounds range anxiety. The irony is delicious. Tesla spent years projecting itself as the future. India has responded by asking for basic practicality. MUSK MYTHOLOGY Yet, dismissing Tesla entirely would be foolish. The brand still possesses something no rival can easily manufacture: myth. Owning a Tesla still signals global sophistication.

It remains aspirational for India's wealthy technology class, start-up founders and luxury buyers seeking differentiation. Elon Musk himself continues to function as a one-man marketing department, capable of generating headlines with a single post online. Tesla also has room to manoeuvre. If the company localises manufacturing, pricing could change dramatically. Lower duties, local assembly and partnerships may help Tesla compete aggressively. There are already conversations around localisation incentives and manufacturing-linked policy support for global EV makers. Most important, Tesla's software ecosystem, autonomous ambitions and over-the-air update capabilities remain ahead of much of the competition. Even sceptics admit that Tesla can shape consumer expectations merely by existing in the market. But India is unlikely to grant Tesla the dominance it enjoyed in parts of the West. This market is too chaotic, too price-sensitive and too competitive for a single messiah-brand to dictate terms. India's EV transition is becoming multipolar, shaped by domestic resilience, Asian manufacturing muscle and relentless consumer scrutiny. The age of effortless disruption is over.

TESLA'S REALITY CHECK

India did not reject Tesla. It negotiated with it. And India negotiates hard. This country's auto market has humbled many giants. Global brands have arrived with swagger and PowerPoint slides, only to discover that Indian consumers possess the world's sharpest instinct for separating hype from value. Tesla's future in India will depend not on celebrity aura, but on whether it can adapt to Indian realities with humility and speed. That means local manufacturing, deeper service networks, affordable offerings and products designed specifically for Indian conditions; not just its imported prestige. Till it manages to do all of the above, Tesla will remain more spectacle than seismic shift. But the larger story is bigger than one company. India's EV battlefield is one of the most consequential auto contests on the planet. Domestic firms are maturing. Asian competitors are surging. Consumers are becoming smarter. Prices are falling. Infrastructure is expanding. And the race has only just begun. Somewhere amid the noise, the traffic and the well-deep potholes, India may yet teach the global EV industry its most important lesson: disruption alone is never enough. In India, survival belongs to those who can localise ambition without losing innovation.



Journeys Through A Burning World



In Shivya Nath's reflective travel memoir, landscapes become living witnesses to climate anxiety, human kindness, inherited displacement and the ethics of movement

AUTHOR

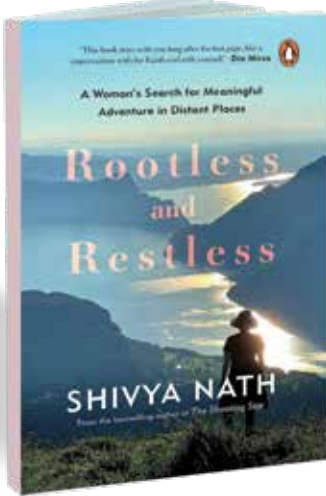


YAUVANIKA CHOPRA

On a moonlit night, a young woman walks alongside three new friends, upon a Caribbean beach where green turtles usually waddle ashore to lay their eggs on the same land they had once hatched. The white sand below unexpectedly gives way to a pervasive brownish grass which the four humans identify as algae. Algae has begun to infest this beach over the years; fewer and fewer turtles are coming to shore.

The woman in our book is the author herself. This chapter is 'Under the Ocean' and is about Cuba in 2018. On her first morning in Cocodrilo (Spanish for crocodile), Shivya had dived into a stunning universe of 55-million-year-old coral reefs whose vibrant colours are bleaching into grey because of plastic waste from ordinary instruments of modernity like water bottles, which take 500 years to erode. The cost of human convenience is unequally borne by the non-human. And there are no easy solutions. Cuba has conserved its natural environmental resources due to a socialist regime, but the flipside of that economic structure is that it curtails individual (now somewhat inherently capitalist) dreams like those of slow travel - Shivya's life calling and profession - for its own citizens. How, she questions, do we contend with a paradoxical world? What is a sustainable balance between consumption and ethics or between individual responsibility and collective fears? Could our personal "handprints" as travellers help offset the global carbon footprint of tourism?

Towards the end of her Cuban trip, as enduring love and urgent worry for the ocean coalesced into overwhelm, Shivya met an elderly islander. Their languages were different and it was unlikely that they would understand each other, but she spoke to him about her increasing anxieties for the future regardless. "As we parted, he tapped his heart with his broad palm, and speaking slowly through rum-thick words, said that we may not understand each other, but we are bound by el idioma del alma—the language



of the soul... As I walked along the pebbly beach, under the last light of the evening, I mulled over his words. The language of the soul connects us not just to each other, but also to all other beings we share this planet with. Perhaps there's hope as long as that remains true."

"Quelat" means the sound of falling water in the language of the nomadic Chono people in Chilean Patagonia, and lends itself to the name of the Hanging Glacier off the Carretera Nacional Highway. To Shivya, "quelat" becomes a word echoing with the promise of working towards a world with better climate awareness for the glaciers which formed 2.6 million years ago and which continue to store nearly 70 percent of all fresh-water on our planet. Much of human history, as Shivya documents along her journeys, has been spent in harmony with these and other ancient ecosystems.

Plant-based food culture, for example, has existed even in spaces which are now known for meat-heavy cuisines. In Japan, the author records that "ito daki mas" is said before every meal as a prayer of gratitude to the plants and animals whose lives are sacrificed for our satiation. Reverence for nature is an ingrained impulse of the Japanese. Travelling through the Kansai countryside, discussing how Shintoism co-exists with Buddhism, Shivya comes upon an unexpected bloom of mitsumata (Oriental paperbush) flowers. "Unlike the planted cherry and plum blossoms, these yellow flowers appeared to be entirely wild and untamed, as though the Earth was exploding with joy at the arrival of spring. Who knows how long they've blossomed in that ancient forest,

and what relationship they share with the lean sky-gazing cedars?"

"Travellers are in too great a rush these days, in a rush to arrive—whatever it takes. But you do not arrive only at your destination. At every stage of the journey you arrive somewhere..." is the quote from Samarkand by Amin Maalouf which begins the chapter on Uzbekistan ('Under the Walnut Tree') in 2019, where Shivya landed one early spring evening for a storytelling project supported by the United States Agency for International Development (USAID). Walking through Tashkent's

THE LANGUAGE OF THE SOUL CONNECTS US NOT JUST TO EACH OTHER, BUT ALSO TO ALL OTHER BEINGS WE SHARE THIS PLANET WITH

Chorsu bazaar and finding herself in an unpleasant situation, she considers the dangers of solo travel as a woman. Debates about courage versus naïveté intertwine within societal realities of gender. There is the kindness of strangers, but also potential for cruelty. "The reason I was okay with those stomach-churning nights before embarking on a solo journey to somewhere unknown was that over time, I felt a deep, unshakable faith in the people I was destined to meet along the way. Especially in a world polarised by religion and politics and the veils we wear both literally and figuratively, I believe our intrinsic character hasn't changed." Risk, and reward: in Bukhara, at the Naqshbandi memorial of 14th-century Sufi saint Baha'uddin, an unforgettable witnessing of the sun descending in a blaze of orange to the sound of Sufi chanting from the shrine.

Shivya had quit her full-time corporate job in Singapore in 2011 to pursue a nomadic existence of travel in adventures, which have been nar-

rated in her best-selling first book, The Shooting Star: A Girl, Her Backpack and the World. In this sequel, family history emerges when, in Myanmar in 2019 ('Off the Map'), the author hears of a local Nath family who have turned their Burmese villa into a House of Memories. Potential roots connect in Amritsar, where her family had travelled overnight during the Partition, burying precious ornaments in the soil of Lahore with a prayer for future retrieval. When riots broke out in Amritsar in the late 1980s, the family left again for Dehradun. Shivya was in her mother's womb at the time, "yet unborn, but journeying on that train with my family's belongings and anxieties."

Meaningful experiences can be found in nearby places. Under the waning moon of the first COVID-19 lockdown, the author finds herself back in her parents' home in Dehradun ('In Limbo'). Between repression and rebellion, rootless and restless, childhood patterns resurface and reconcile. And, still yearning to hear stories from other geographies, there is collaboration with Malika Virdi of Himalayan Ark and Osama Manzar of the Digital Empowerment Foundation for an initiative called Voices of Rural India, featuring tales from people in remote Kerala, Ladakh and Spiti in a fulfilling endeavour of exploration. Re-cognising one's changing self in the home and the world is its own journey.

On other moonlit nights, Shivya takes us to Isfahan, the former capital of the Safavid empire, where the once perennial Zayandeh River has run dry. Closer home, she describes a full-moon conversation in Bastar about 'ghotul', where Gonds and other forward-thinking communities provide space for exploratory consensual relationships between teenagers. And there are sunrises (although sometimes, she admits, these are missed because of the understandable desire to sleep in just a little longer), alongside days and weeks recorded with a sensory vividness that transports the reader too. Whether the humans around her are humbly affectionate (like on Robinson Crusoe Island) or icily aloof (as happened through Switzerland), Shivya's sense of wonder for our planet and universe thrums as the baseline for this extraordinary memoir. There are no simple answers to continuing questions — but many paths to understanding through conscious choice, and the faith that perhaps expeditions well-conducted could help us find freedom at the ends of the rainbows we follow.

INLAND



PREDICTING A WARMING PLANET

From IPCC pathways to local flood planning, climate models shape global policy despite their uncertainties and limitations

AUTHOR



KRISHNA GUPTA

We saw that climate models are not ideally suited to predicting climate decades or centuries from now. This is because climate is changing in unpredictable ways, and the rate of change itself is uncertain. To add to that, many of the assumptions made in climate models to represent local or small-scale processes (referred to as parameterisation) pose problems in prediction. Finally, many of the IPCC models, such as the Representative Concentration Pathways (RCPs) and Shared Socioeconomic Pathways (SSPs), which have been referred to above, have made some implausible assumptions. For example, one of the RCP models assumes that the use of coal in the next 70-80 years will rise six-fold by 2100, when it may have already peaked. The problem is that the IPCC models are used in many research papers in the sciences and social sciences, and the errors creep in there as well. We are back to the question: how can climate models help in public policy-making and decision-making? Let us discuss this in greater detail.

APPLICATIONS TO PUBLIC POLICY

Outputs of climate change models, such as temperature, rainfall, wind velocity, etc., are generally available at the grid level, which tends to be a cell of dimensions 100 km by 100 km. To make this useful at the local level, results of GCM simulations are integrated with historical observations at the regional or city level. One such attempt was made by combining GCMs with Auto-Regressive Integrated Moving Average (ARIMA) models to give city-based predictions for temperature and rainfall for engineering applications (for more details, the article by Lai and Dzombak, published in the Journal of Meteorology and Climatology in May 2021, may be referred to).

In his book Predicting Our Climate Future, David Stainforth has argued that GCM or ESM models have limitations and cannot be used to predict climate precisely. Instead, he says that an alternative would be to look at local time series of important variables such as temperature, rainfall, and humidity, and assess the probability of their crossing a defined threshold. These thresholds could be those that are important for various things, such as overheating risks or the ability of humans to work beyond a certain temperature. Stainforth also warns against pushing for the "perfect" climate model, for there can be no such thing. Instead, the focus should be on how best to achieve specific objectives to reduce the risks

from climate change and better adapt to it. Stainforth also lays great store by a multidisciplinary approach to climate change and its consequences, where social science and physical science should remain in constant dialogue.

Another approach was proposed by Swiss researchers Reto Knutti and Markus Huber, who looked at a time series of data on temperature and humidity from around the world for each day since 2000. From this data, they extracted a "fingerprint" of radiative forcing (warming caused by greenhouse gases, aerosols, etc.) and used this to separate anthropogenic warming from natural warming. They take this to be evidence of global warming and climate change.

Another recent example of climate models being used in policy is that of the UK Climate Projections 2018 (UKCP18). The UKCP18 used GCMs and regional climate models to predict rainfall, temperature, storm intensity, and sea-level rise till 2100, and used these projections to make an infrastructure plan to mitigate flood risks. Similarly, NASA's sea-level rise prediction model has been used by New York City planners for better coastal planning.

CLIMATE MODELS

may not perfectly predict the future, but they remain central to decisions on infrastructure, energy transition, adaptation and climate resilience across the world

In the Climate Change series of articles over the last year or so, we have covered various aspects of mitigation and adaptation. Many of these, such as policy in the energy, transport, agriculture, and industry sectors, have benefited from the various outputs of climate models and the comparisons run under CMIP by the IPCC. Issues such as Net Zero pathways, to which each country has committed, decarbonization, energy transition, creating climate-resilient infrastructure, and the phase-out of fossil fuels have perhaps been decided on the basis of simulations from climate models.

CONCLUSION

Climate change models are a useful tool, but not a panacea for managing all climate change consequences, or even for predicting future climate. Economic models, such as the Integrated Assessment Models (IAMs), also have their limitations, as we discussed in an earlier article. It is also true that the basic laws of physics have established that climate change is a reality, and that global warming has not only been happening as a result of human intervention, but will also accelerate if timely action is not taken. Hence, the best way forward is to realize the limitations of models and work with the data to see how our objectives on mitigation and adaptation can be met.

When Reputation Isn't Enough

Rishabh Pant and Hardik Pandya, once IPL's biggest bets, now face scrutiny as form dips, leadership falters and expectations turn unforgiving

AUTHOR



S KANNAN

Rishabh Pant's loss of confidence as a batter and captain of the Lucknow Super Giants in the Indian Premier League (IPL) has become the butt of ridicule. Harsh words have been said about the south-paw, with former cricketers like Shaun Pollock mincing no words when they describe him as "aimless" these days.

Indeed, Pant's story is one of flights of fancy, where, not long back, he was compared with Australian legend Adam Gilchrist. For those who have followed the 28-year-old Pant's career for over a decade, he has been bold and beautiful. Yet, how he has collapsed in the last few years in the IPL, at two teams—Delhi Capitals and LSG—tells you a big story.

As recently as last year, during India's Test tour to England, Rishabh Pant had made his presence felt strongly. The voice of someone constantly indulging in chatter, caught on the stump microphone, is pronounced. But then, how the wicketkeeper has been injured repeatedly and come back also tells you about Pant's resilience.

To borrow a tennis phrase, it is a break point now for Pant, as LSG struggle at rock bottom in the IPL 2026 edition. To break down Pant and his failures is easy. As a batter, the surprise element in his aggressive batting approach has been decoded. When the auction for the 2025 IPL was held, Rishabh Pant showed he was a real blue-chip, fetching an astonishing price of Rs 27 crores. That auction was held after the ICC T20 World Cup, where India had triumphed in the West Indies in the summer of 2024.

Pant had then decided he was packing up from Delhi Capitals and wanted to test his value at the IPL auction. He did grab eyeballs when he commanded such a massive price. However, just as Pant, as captain of the Delhi Capitals franchise, never performed at optimum, his stint as LSG captain for two years in a row has plummeted to abysmal depths of despair. For those who loved Pant when he fought his way back after the horrific car crash in December 2022, which involved surgery, intense rehab and immense willpower, to see him struggle like this is a sad sight. Everyone wants to see him bounce back, but time is running out.

The way he has bobbed up and down the batting order for LSG has forced experts and fans to slam him. Frankly speaking, Rishabh Pant, the batter in Test cricket who has produced classic knocks in Eng-



PANT'S STRUGGLES

- » ₹27 CRORE BURDEN OF EXPECTATIONS
- » CAPTAINCY UNDER PRESSURE AT LSG
- » ERRATIC ROLE IN BATTING ORDER

PANDYA'S PROBLEMS

- » INCONSISTENT ALL-ROUND PERFORMANCES
- » CAPTAINCY QUESTIONS AT MUMBAI INDIANS
- » OFF-FIELD DISTRACTIONS UNDER SPOTLIGHT

land and Australia, has been decoded. In the IPL, so many inputs go into each team. Each batter is decoded, each bowler is decoded. There is so much about strategy, planning and execution that the IPL becomes one of the best 'schools' as well for cricketers.

In this school, if Pant has not learnt lessons for years in a row, it tells you how weak he stands today. This is specifically talking about his batting. As someone used to mocking bowlers with audacious strokeplay, Pant is now a caricature of the self he was when he emerged as the Nawab of Lucknow at the IPL auction in December 2024.

Memes on Pant, and how he interacts with the LSG owner, a hard taskmaster, are viral on social media. When Pant was bought at Rs 27 crores, Sanjiv Goenka saw in him a leader who would rise to dizzy heights and become as famous as Rohit Sharma when he was the Mumbai Indians captain. For sure, such statements were only adding pressure on Pant.

The best of cricketers also go through bad phases, be it as a batter or bowler. Sample the 2026 IPL—rock star Jasprit Bumrah has been made to look so average. But then, Bumrah will not be judged on IPL performances alone. What he has done repeatedly for India will define him. India still looks up to BOOM as a match-winner, especially in Test cricket.

Pant faces uncertainty ahead in his career. It is not just about the IPL. The world's richest and most exciting T20 cricket league, despite a drop in TV viewership figures, continues to stay top of mind. Look at this season—how youngsters are faring as well as seasoned

FROM RECORD PRICE TAGS TO MOUNTING CRITICISM, TWO OF INDIAN CRICKET'S MOST flamboyant stars ARE CONFRONTING THE HARSH REALITY OF PERFORMANCE-DRIVEN SPORT

knows he needs to sort out his batting. It has gone bust.

IPL is one part which could have redefined Rishabh Pant. His position in the Indian Test team is still unchallenged, but given the BCCI's methods of evolving and building teams, there is a lurking fear that Rishabh Pant in ODIs will also become history. One saw last year how KL Rahul was preferred as wicketkeeper-batter in the Champions Trophy. If the current trend continues, there is every reason to believe Sanju Samson, star of India's T20 World Cup win this year, can next make it to the ODIs.

Is Pant finished, or can he make amends? There are two aspects to this. Pant has to shed ego, and he has to walk up to the people he feels can guide him. There is every bit of negative news around the superstar and how he is recalcitrant. Perhaps Pant needs to draw lessons from MS Dhoni, someone he has idolised. When Dhoni had issues with his batting grip well over 15 years back, he was ready to talk to coaches and correct his mistakes.

Either Pant has to realise himself that he needs to make amends, or he will lose out. As it stands, he is no longer in the mix for Team India in the T20 format. If his position is threatened further across all formats, he has to show intent and commitment like two former India captains who define commitment—Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma. If not, Pant will go down as a cricketer who could not handle success and was never worth the price he went for in the IPL. After all, Shreyas Iyer, who fetched Rs 25 crores at the auction, has been 'paisa vasool' for Punjab Kings.

Gazing at flop shows in the IPL 2026 edition, it is a reminder that no player is bigger than the game. See how Hardik Pandya has failed to handle success. Not only has he failed as an all-rounder, his captaincy at Mumbai Indians now looks to be hanging by a fine thread. Officially, the talk is that Pandya has 'back' issues. Those in the business of news are aware that Hardik Pandya has become a pain for the team. His public behaviour has also become a talking point. Images of him walking around holding his girlfriend's hand are not in good taste. He can do all this in private space, not constantly in the public domain.

A cricketer will be defined and tolerated by his performance, not off-field activity, which comes under the lens. There are more telling images of Hardik Pandya not behaving maturely with his teammates at Mumbai Indians. The most high-profile IPL team will not tolerate rank indiscipline. MI had set high performance standards in the past. Today, big bosses at MI must be regretting what a big mistake it was to bring in Hardik Pandya from the Gujarat Titans to Mumbai.

The bubble has burst. Like Rishabh Pant, Hardik Pandya too can be jettisoned. Pandya plays only the T20 international format. Once the BCCI selectors are convinced his commitment is lacking, it is the end. With Ajit Agarkar in command for one more year as chairman of the selection committee and Gautam Gambhir the coach, non-performers with poor appraisals are going to face the heat. After all, performance in the IPL is not just about club cricket. It is taken note of, with saturation coverage in conventional media as well as social media. Indeed, the summer heat is on for two superstars—Rishabh Pant and Hardik Pandya.



Federation Notice

The Wrestling Federation of India issued a show-cause notice to Vinesh Phogat, alleging indiscipline and anti-doping violations. The federation declared her ineligible for domestic competitions till June 26, 2026, citing failure to complete the mandatory six-month notice period after retirement. She has been given 14 days to respond.



Title Rivals

D. Gukesh suffered a defeat against Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov in the Blitz round of the Super Rapid and Blitz Poland 2026. Playing with white pieces, Gukesh resigned after 46 moves under severe time pressure. Sindarov has now beaten him twice in the tournament ahead of their World Championship clash later this year.



Anfield talemate

Chelsea F.C. ended their six-match losing streak with a 1-1 Premier League draw against Liverpool F.C. at Anfield. Enzo Fernández cancelled out Ryan Gravenberch's opener with a free-kick equaliser, earning caretaker manager Calum MacFarlane his first point in charge ahead of Chelsea's FA Cup final clash.

DOWN IN THE DUMPS

RISHABH PANT'S LOW RUN WITH THE BAT HAS HIGHLIGHTED THE STRUGGLES IN THE LAST TWO SEASONS OF BOTTOM-PLACED LUCKNOW SUPER GIANTS UNDER HIS CAPTAINCY.

In IPL 2025
(Matches Played: 14)
Runs Scored

269

Best 118* Strike rate 133.16

AVERAGE 24.45

In IPL 2026
(Matches Played: 10)
Runs Scored

236

Best 68* Strike rate 139.64

AVERAGE 29.50

AS Captain

YEAR	MATCHES	Won	Lost
2025	14	6	8
2026	10	3	7



INDONESIA

PRIDE OF HINDU CULTURAL HERITAGE

Hindu influence is equally visible in Indonesian names

ASIF ULLAH KHAN

People say I'm greedy because I named my daughter Annisa Laksmi Saraswati," senior 'Jakarta Post' journalist Primastuti Handayani told me over coffee during an 'Asian News Network' conference in Hanoi.

A devout Muslim who wears a headscarf even while travelling abroad, Primastuti explained, "I want my daughter to have both knowledge and wealth. Our ancestors were Hindus and Muslims and Hindu heritage has both enriched us culturally. We have the best of both worlds." At a time when much of the Muslim world is grappling with radicalisation, her words were refreshing.

Indonesia, the world's largest Muslim-majority country, also faces pressure from fundamentalists. Yet Hindu cultural influence remains deeply woven into public and social life and even hardline groups have rarely challenged it.

When Jakarta hosted the 1997 Southeast Asian Games, the mascot was Lord Hanuman, who is also the mascot of Indonesia's military intelligence agency. The 20,000-rupiah note once carried an image of Lord Ganesha, revered as the god of wisdom and prosperity.



LORD VISHNU, OR WISNU IN Indonesian, OCCUPIES A UNIQUE PLACE IN THE NATIONAL IMAGINATION

Hindu influence is equally visible in Indonesian names. Primastuti pointed out that Indonesia's first president, Sukarno, was named after Karna from the 'Mahabharata'. His father admired the character but disapproved of his loyalty to the Kauravas, so he prefixed the name with 'Su', meaning good.

Lord Vishnu, or Wisnu in Indonesian, occupies a unique place in the national imagination. Garuda, Vishnu's mythical mount, is Indonesia's national emblem as well as the name of its national airline.

The clearest expression of this heritage is the Garuda Wisnu Kencana (GWK) Cultural Park in Bali's Badung region. Spread across more than 100 hectares, the park centres on a colossal statue of Vishnu riding Garuda, designed by renowned sculptor I Nyoman Nuarta. At 120 metres high and 64 metres wide, the completed monument is intended to surpass both the

Statue of Liberty and Rio de Janeiro's Christ the Redeemer in scale.

When I visited, different sections of the monument - Vishnu's bust, Garuda's head and Vishnu's hands - stood separately across the park. Even unfinished, the sculptures offered a breathtaking spectacle.

Behind the Vishnu statue lies 'Parahyangan Somaka Giri', a spring considered sacred because of its mineral-rich water and unusual location atop a limestone hill. The site has become a place for meditation and spiritual reflection.

Near the entrance stand limestone statues of Rama, Sita, Lakshmana, Ravana, Kumbhakarna and Vibhisana, another reminder of how deeply the Ramayana shapes Indonesian culture.

On my way back from GWK, I noticed a billboard for the blockbuster Indonesian film 'Ayat-Ayat Cinta' (Verses of Love), produced by Manoj Punjabi. Along with his uncle Raam Punjabi, the Hindu producer is among the biggest names in Indonesian cinema. Ironically, Manoj's greatest success came from a film rooted in Islamic themes. Based on a best-selling novel, 'Ayat-Ayat Cinta' was praised internationally for presenting a humane image of Islam.

"I'm Indian; I'm Hindu, but I'm as Indonesian as it gets," Manoj once said in an interview. "I promote Indonesia. I fight for it, I believe in it." That sentiment captures the essence of Indonesia.

The country is no utopia and continues to face the threat of extremism. Yet Hindus, who make up only about two per cent of the population, have largely avoided the sectarian violence seen elsewhere. When BJP leader L K Advani visited Jakarta in 2010 for the World Sindhi Conference, he reportedly expressed admiration for the respect Indonesia's Muslim majority shows toward Hindu traditions.

As I left Bali, I noticed the Garuda Pancasila, Indonesia's national emblem, designed by Sultan Hamid II. A Hindu mythical figure designed by a Muslim and embraced as the symbol of the world's largest Muslim-majority nation is both surreal and heartening.

Perhaps Primastuti was right after all: Indonesia truly has the best of both worlds.

RITEISH DESHMUKH ON DECADE LONG JOURNEY OF 'RAJA SHIVAJI'

'ALMOST GAVE UP, BUT IT KEPT COMING BACK'



The historical epic chronicles the life of the Maratha Empire's founder, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj

KOMAL PANCHAMATIA

For actor-filmmaker Riteish Deshmukh, the decade-long struggle to bring his dream project, 'Raja Shivaji', to life wasn't easy. He said the wait ultimately proved to be a blessing in disguise as it allowed him to make it 'bigger and better'.

Released on May 1, the historical epic chronicles the life of the Maratha Empire's founder, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. Deshmukh not only stars in the titular role but has also co-written and directed it. The film was first announced in 2016, then stalled, revived again in 2019, only to be pushed back due to the COVID-19 pandemic until 2023, when Deshmukh decided to give it a 'final shot'.

Acclaimed directors like Ravi Jadhav and Nagraj Manjule were attached as directors, but eventually Deshmukh decided to take on the responsibility of directing it as well.

"I feel relieved because this 10-year journey was pretty long. Many a time, one gave up on it, but it came back to you. Had it started in 2016, this wouldn't be the film; it would be a different film, a different star cast. The fact that it started in 2023, the vision changed a bit, perspectives changed and then we just thought, 'Why not make it slightly bigger and more ambitious?'" Deshmukh told PTI in an interview.

He added, "The journey changed course over time and now that the film is out and the way it's received, I'm just truly humbled and I just want to thank God and the people of Maharashtra for receiving this film so well."

Looking back, the actor-director said the multiple delays worked in the film's favour. He credits actor-wife Genelia D'Souza, who stars opposite him in 'Raja Shivaji' and has also produced the film, for making it a grand Marathi-Hindi bilingual epic by roping in Bollywood stars.

The film boasts of a star-studded cast including Sanjay Dutt as Afzal Khan, Abhishek Bachchan as Sambhaji Shahaji Bhonsale, Vidya Balan as Badi Begum and Salman Khan in a cameo. "Then Jio Studios came on board. Jyoti Deshpande backed the vision and then Genelia, as a producer, told me, 'Apart from fantastic actors from the Marathi industry, why don't we look at casting from the Hindi film industry, make it really big, let the legs stretch a bit beyond the boundaries of this Maharashtra, Marathi-speaking population'"

Making a film on Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj came with a lot of responsibility, Deshmukh said, adding that the writing process took nearly two years. He and Genelia have co-produced the movie via their banner 'Mumbai Film Company'. The team carefully researched multiple historical books, including 'Vedhi Mahamanavacha', 'Shree Raja Shivchhatrapati', 'Shivcharitra', 'Shree Shivbharat' and others.

"This film is not based on just one



The film was first announced in 2016, then stalled, revived again in 2019, only to be pushed back due to the COVID-19 pandemic until 2023, when he decided to give it a 'final shot'

book; it is basically extractions of incidents from various history books. It's placed and woven into a narrative that maintains the dignity of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj and explains his journey that starts from his birth to eventually the killing of Sardar (Afzal Khan), played by Sanjay Dutt," Deshmukh said.

The actor described the legendary Maratha ruler as a childhood 'superhero', whose legacy has been passed down through generations of his family.

"The first story that every Maharashtra boy hears is of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. When my dad (late Vilasrao Deshmukh) was sworn in as the chief minister for the first time and he went to Mantralaya and the first namaste was to the portrait of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. That's how it's ingrained into everyone's lives and veins and blood. That's what he means to us. There would be discussions about his valour at home and one of my earliest stories on Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj was told to me by my mother and father," said Deshmukh, who debuted as a producer in Marathi cinema with 'Balak Palak' (2013) and made his acting debut the subsequent year with 'Lai Bhaari' (2014).

'Raja Shivaji' has received praise for its performances and emotional depth, but some criticism has been directed at certain technical aspects, including visual effects. Addressing the criticism, Deshmukh said that not every film can meet everyone's expectations. "I take the criticism in my stride and it is a big learning curve," he said.

AGENCIES

WHAT THE HORROR!

Here is a selection of OTT scary offerings from 'Netflix' for you to binge-watch!

OUR CORRESPONDENT

With the popularity and views growing rapidly after the release of the much-talked-about Korean young horror thriller 'If Wishes Could Kill', many people are asking themselves: what other horror content is left to watch?

Missed any of these binge-worthy films and series in the genres of horror, supernatural and thriller? Then check out the list to add them to your watchlist!

SVAHA: THE SIXTH FINGER (2019)

Starring Lee Jung-jae (Squid Games), the film is a blend of mystery, supernatural horror and crime thriller. It follows a minister who asks his Buddhist monk friend for help investigating a new group with mysterious origins.



INCANTATION (2022)



The Taiwanese cult horror film, inspired by a true story, is a mix of supernatural terror and raw human emotions following a mother who, after breaking a religious taboo, is now cursed and hellbent on protecting her daughter.

The viewers allege the film to be eerily scary.

DEATH WHISPERER (2023)

Although a movie with jump scares and village vibes, the Thai film does not disappoint its viewers. With creepy and eerie village vibes and scenes that definitely make one jump scare unexpectedly, this one is a must-watch.



ALL OF US ARE DEAD (2022)



Who can ever forget the popular and zombie-based series of high schoolers who fight for survival amid a dangerous zombie outbreak? A must-watch Korean thriller for people who have yet to find this gem and enjoy the twists and turns!

THE BRIDGE CURSE (2020)

The Taiwanese film is a clever horror story that carefully hides the plot twist until the end. The story follows a reporter who digs into the 2016 gruesome murders of five college students who died while going to an alleged haunted bridge. A great watch as a beginner film for horror fans!

